Altitude

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/29425515.

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Mature

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
This Is Sad, very sad, Catra has PTSD - Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (She-Ra), Catra has BPD, Flashbacks, Angst, Smut, Childhood Friends, It gets heavy later on, Minor Original Character(s), Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Catra almost dies three separate times, Later it stops being as smutty, Crimson Waste (She-Ra), Catra has bad coping mechanisms, Catra gets therapy in this one, but at the end, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption

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English

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Part 1 of A Path of Rediscovery

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Altitude

by RationsandSpades

Summary

Catra wants to feel something again. It's been a month since she opened the portal, a week since Scorpia abandoned her. A week since she's been completely and utterly alone. Catra will do anything to make herself feel better. Desperate to be loved again, desperate to feel, she does whatever she can to cope.

Takes place after the portal incident and during the beginning of Season 4. A Catra-centered fanfic about what could have been.

Notes

Thank you so much for all the love on my other fics! I really appreciate it! This'll be the first smut fic I post here. It's going to be a multi-chapter fic this time because I want to actually try something new for once.

See the end of the work for more notes

But a Little Silence

Another day, another person.

They scrambled to reach the door in time. Catra's fingers were gentle and controlled as she typed in the password with ease. It was the other woman that was needy, that was impatient. Even in the hallway, she was clinging to her side, peppering her neck with soft kisses. Her breathing was already fast.

"I can't wait to get my hands on you," the woman said.

"Moons…" Catra said, a low growl. She finally unlocked the door, shoved the woman in, and locked it behind them.

She nearly launched herself at the other woman, shoving her against the bed, pressing her against her chest. Their lips clashed and Catra wasted no time making mincemeat of her lips as she bit down and pawed hungrily at the woman's chest and her sides.

Hands, needy, clinging to shirts desperately, dug into fabric with the desperation of a man drowning in the sea.

"Catra," she said.

She didn't respond, letting her lips talk for her. She bit down on tonight's lover's neck hard. The other woman's breath hitched, shaking, breathy, a long sigh.

"Catra," she said again.

Could she shut up?

"Catra. Take this off," she said. She scrambled and fumbled with Catra's zipper. Her hands brushed against Catra's fur and-

Her skin, too smooth to be Adora's. Too smooth, her shirt too tight against her body. Adora would never be seen in a shirt that fucking tight.

Catra leaned back. She glanced over at the door to the hall, making sure that the door was closed and that it was properly locked. Satisfied, she looked at Not Adora and wordlessly unzipped the bodysuit. It crumpled in a heap at her hips and she lunged forward to catch the woman in another hard kiss. All teeth, desperate and with hurricane force.

Luckily, she didn't talk for a little bit, only balling her fists in her hair when Catra trailed kisses down her body, across her chest. Catra looked up at her and met the other woman's eyes.

Blue. Not quite that same baby blue as Adora's, but pretty close.

Close enough.

She kept eye contact as she ran her nails down the woman's body. This woman she never bothered to learn the name of. She should know her name, being the second-in-command of the Horde and all. It didn't matter, nothing mattered.

Her eyes screwed shut as Catra's nails dug into smooth and soft flesh and she bit down on her shoulder. She straddled her, pulling her close.

"It's okay. You can do this," Adora said, eyes so soft as Catra looked over at her.

She gave her a small smile she hoped was kind and loving, some way to tell her she loved her.

She looked back at the paper and pointed to the kingdoms' names scribbled out on the paper.

She could read it, of course, it was Adora's handwriting after all. Still, she feigned ignorance.

"Moons, Adora, you're illiterate," she said with a chuckle.

A scoff and Catra felt her shake the bunk with a small laugh.

"Kingdom of Plumeria. Ruled by…" she squinted and leaned closer, "...Princess...P...Per"

"Persephone," Catra growled.

That was her name.

How pretty.

Persephone gasped and shook as Catra's fingers went to work. Catra had her claws sheathed so that she wouldn't hurt her.

"Catra…"

Catra hummed and gave her lover's neck a soft lick with her hooked tongue. She could feel her shake under the pads of her fingers and her mouth. She wanted to leave marks, wanted to tear her apart. She was holding onto her desperately, fingers digging into Catra's shoulders and back. She had her face buried in the crook of Catra's neck and was panting.

Faster, faster, faster.

"Catra!"

It almost sounded like her. How Catra imagined she'd sound if she ever made her call her name like that. It was always strangled grunts back when they were going solo. Catra would listen in, wondering what she was thinking of, who she was thinking of.

What was getting her off?

Was it her?

It would never be her.

She bit down on Persephone's neck and shook her head, allowing her teeth to dig into the soft skin. She imagined she was biting into Adora's. Was she trying to kill her? Hurt her?

"Fuck-"

Strangled gasping, shaking, twitching.

Whimpering.

Stillness.

"Fuck…" the woman said.

Catra released her grip on the woman and leaned back to look over her. If she imagined hard enough, she could almost imagine the short-haired woman to be Adora with a haircut. The woman's hair was mussed, sky eyes cloudy, glazed over but looking at her still. She was catching her breath.

She put back on her bodysuit with a loud zip and looked at the residue coating her fingers. She spread her fingers, closing them again, and balled her hand into a fist.

"Catra...come here. Please?" she said.

Catra looked at her. She looked at this woman. This bastardization of Adora. Some sort of twisted image of her that had taken over her. Her features were too soft, too short, too thin.

Catra's mouth curled into a snarl. "Leave," she said.

Please don't go. Please don't go.

"Catra?" the woman, glory in her nakedness, held her messed up clothes to her chest. "Are you-"

" *Go!"* she shouted. She hissed and unsheathed her claws.

The woman flinched, eyes snapping clear and wide. They shined and she fumbled to put on her clothes in a hurry.

She couldn't stand to look at her, look at this horrible image that was some sort of twisted Adora. Some sort of horrible...thing she decided to give in to. Her breaths were coming out ragged and she waited until the woman was out of the room.

Silence enveloped the room again. The lights would soon be going out as lights out slowly came.

Slowly, slowly.

Her fingers were tacky now, thick and sticky despite not being wet anymore. She felt herself shaking, her vision blurring, everything starting to go numb again. Her chest heaved, her eyes darted around the room. She hissed and stormed her way to the sink.

With a swift movement, she shoved her hands into the blisteringly hot water and gritted her teeth as the water burned the sensitive pads on her hands. Tears stung her eyes, her claws fully unsheathed, the room now getting dimmer. She let boiling water from the tap she didn't remember turning on cascade into her cupped hands and splashed it onto her face. She whined and shut off the water in a hurry. The sink was cold against her hot face pressed against it. She turned her face away, eyes shut.

Persephone's face kept showing up in her mind's eye.

The woman's face, terrified, concerned.

"Damnit!" she slammed a fist down onto the edge of the sink and looked at her reflection in the mirror. Her eyes were still dilated, blown into black circles. Her chest was shaking, unsteady, back arched. Everything about her screamed tired. The bags and shadows under her eyes were heavier than they were yesterday, having deepened since last night's nightmare. Each one had gotten steadily worse. Each one more vivid, terrible, horrible.

She turned away from her reflection and walked to her bed. With a swift and easy jump, she landed on the hard surface. She unzipped her bodysuit and stripped, putting on her Horde-issued pajamas with ease. The fabric was cold, like everything else in this fucking room. If she got any warmer, her breath would start fogging up in the air. Maybe she'd start shivering for once in her life.

Everything was too loud, too quiet, too big, too small.

Distant.

She lay back in the bed, not bothering to cover herself in the sheets yet. Her eyes were fixed to the ceiling. The ceiling, unmoving, quiet, cold, dark. Nothing was working.

Nothing was working.

She didn't even notice the lights go out. Everything seemed…

Distant.

Foggy.

She found herself spacing out, remembering, thinking, wondering, as she moved in slow motion. She pushed her clothes off of the bed, letting them crumple onto the floor. Her eyes lingered on them. The Horde insignia blazed bright against the black background. It mocked her, but she didn't even care.

How could she?

She lay back again, pulling the covers over her shaking body cold with the finally chilly room.

The room was completely black by the time she started to feel tired.

"Adora…" she said. She tested the name, let it roll off her tongue. She felt the beginning of tears prick at her eyes as she thought of the times when they were still together. Even in the portal reality, it would've been Adora here. She would be sleeping with her, at the foot of her bed, while Adora slept under the sheets. She'd be there to comfort her if she woke up screaming. That was her role. Adora would sometimes fight in her sleep, would wake up with a jolt, and Catra would be there to comfort her.

Always there for one another.

Always together.

Why couldn't it be like that again?

"Because you left me. You abandoned me," she said, an attempt at a hiss into the darkness of the room.

Behind her eyes, nightmares already started to flash. She heard Persephone's voice again, calling her name in her passion. She heard Adora's voice there instead. She heard she heard, she heard…

"Adora…" she said, a whimper. "I love you."

How it Would Be Here With You

Chapter Summary

> There's been too much going on, too much happening. She needs another body in her bed and her claws to dig into her head.
> Anything to make the nightmares go away, to give her something to live for.

Chapter Notes

> Thanks for all the love shown on my first chapter with the ratio of hits to kudos, y'all! I know people are more hesitant to read unfinished works and smut. Also! This chapter has some dialogue that could be triggering in it. It's pretty obviously emotionally abusive content-wise. There's also sexy times, as one could expect from this fic for now. Ahm so excited to write more of this that I accidentally wrote the next three chapters, plus the ending already. Ahm just writing it all and polishing it with my beta reader. Thanks, FC!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra woke up with a start. She clutched the sheets, wet with sweat and heart pounding in her chest. The world blurred, sharpened, relaxed.

Today was a new day.

The clock ticked on, analog, each sound almost grating as she heard its internal workings. Each little grinding of the gears deafening in the silent room.

Still early. The Horde would be awake soon. The action of the day’s activities would be starting in two hours.

Two hours and what? Two hours to sit in bed, staring at the ceiling, begging for sleep and yet dreading every second her eyes

closed. She took shaky breaths to try and slow her racing heart. The heat of the dream filled her mind. Every scene, every drop of blood shed, vividly played out in record time through racing thoughts and dirty mind tarnished with the blood on her claws.

She closed her eyes.

She gave in.

And the record started to play again.

-

Catra was running. She was running through a field of flowers full of thorns and berries that would never hurt her. Every step she took, every stride of her lithe and powerful body, left behind a trail of crushed and broken flowers. No thorns, regardless of how much they pricked and clutched onto her with their clingy talons, would hurt her. Yes, they were a nuisance, bothering and slowing her down, but never hurt her.

Powerful.

She stood up, stretching her back and looking at the field in front of her. The field she knew she would own, the one she knew was hers and hers only.

A bang reverberated through the air.

She didn’t even flinch.

Her ears swiveled and she lazily turned to face the sound.

The tanks went through the field. They crushed every shred of life, every flower, every living thing, under their massive treads. They launched blasts that obliterated every inch of the ground.

She stood there.

Yet no smile graced her face, no satisfaction came out of this. She wanted this, right?

As she watched the tanks commit their acts of violence, shred up the land with their treads and set fire to all the beauty and life in this verdant field of vivid technicolor flowers and vibrant berries, she felt no satisfaction. No joy came out of watching these tanks move.

It turned into something else.

In front of her, She-Ra was standing. Her sword drawn, the air around her practically glowing with her sheer and raw *power* . It was blinding, terrible, horrible. Everything about it filled every cell in her body with rage.

She gritted her teeth and dropped onto all fours. With a lunge, she started her run.

She-Ra went further away.

The tanks charged towards this image of who she once loved, who tarnished and destroyed her Adora. The flowers around her were growing again, the grass sprouting.

She raised her sword and, with a sweep of shimmering light, cut the tanks into a mess of broken machinery and destruction. Catra hardly had time to blink.

All she could do was try and run, try and stop her. She was getting further away, her Adora leaving, She-Ra was getting further, she watched, she watched, she watched.

“Stop! Stop it!” she cried out, tearing at the grass desperately underfoot as She-Ra continued to wreak havoc on the Horde. All that she had worked for, all that she had done, destroyed.

And then she turned her attention to Catra.

And the world was getting closer, She-Ra was coming for her, each step bringing her miles closer, it seemed.

Catra couldn't move now. Something was holding her down, something was keeping her in place. She couldn't look away from the approaching threat, this warrior goddess covering miles with each step she took.

"Adora, please," Catra said.

What was she even asking for?

Adora was getting closer now. She could see on her arms veins red as the blood that roared in her ears crisscrossing their surface.

Catra tugged at her restraints, the shadow tendrils keeping her locked in place. "Adora!" she struggled. "Adora! Wait! Stop!"

Adora lifted her sword, her red eyes gleaming dangerously empty.

The world went silent.

The sword came down.

Catra screamed.

She convulsed as the sword kept coming down on her, each strike gashing open her body. She couldn't move, couldn't dodge. All she could do was stay in place as blow after fatal blow was delivered.

"Useless! Worthless piece of garbage," Adora spat at her as she slashed with her sword. She kicked the helpless cat with a strong kick that had her gag onto the perfect, pristine field. "I never loved you! I never will love you. Nobody will ever love such a useless pile of shit," she said.

Darkness and death wasn't coming for her until she twitched, looking up at Adora.

Adora looked at her with a twisted grimace on her She-Ra face.

“Adora…please,” she said, weakly, smelling blood. Her vision was fading but she still saw the sword come down.

-

“Stop!” Catra shouted as she jerked in her bed. Her chest heaved with every breath and she felt the beginnings of tears pricking her eyes.

The world blurred, her chest kept heaving.

She desperately felt herself, making sure her limbs were still intact and that she was still alive. Her heart pounded in her chest and she shook. It reminded her of when she was dunked into a pool of freezing cold water, Shadow Weaver goading her on to swim.

Her breaths came out shallow as the dream kept playing. She couldn’t move. She flexed her hands, curled her fingers, trying to console herself, remind herself somehow that she was still here.

All she could feel was the sword coming down on her, each slash crippling and destroying.

She curled up, body shaking as she held her head with unsheathed claws and flexed fingers, flinching at every single click and pop of distant machinery.

“Adora…” she whimpered, holding herself now. “Adora, I’m sorry. Please...come back…”

Her cries went unheard beneath the blare of the morning alarm that reverberated through the speakers in the distant barracks.

“Fuck-“ she shot up. The room was cold against her fur and she curled up, holding her legs.

No. No, she was Catra. C’yra. She didn’t know her last name, never had one.

"Catra Applesauce Meowmeow!" Adora said proudly. She smiled wide and crossed her arms.

"That's terrible! I'm calling you Adora…" Catra looked around, trying to find something to name her after.

Spotted!

"Adora Rations Idiot," she said.

Adora frowned, "No! It can't be that!"

"Uh, it is now!"

"No! I mean- my name has to be Adora Rations Meowmeow! We're going to marry each other, remember?"

"Well we're not married now," Catra said. She shifted herself on the floor and held the crayon between chubby fingers. "So your last name is still Idiot."

Adora huffed and looked away, staying silent.

Catra rolled her eyes and looked at their drawings on the wall.

Adora was still quiet.

"Seriously? Fine! I'll be Idiot then," Catra said.

Adora shook her head, "We're the Meowmeows, not the Idiots."

"Okay, geez. We're the Meowmeows," Catra said. She reached forward and scribbled their names onto the wall. She leaned back and they admired her handiwork. The letters looked very readable and very clear.

Perfect. Just like she always wanted to be.

"It just sounds good," Adora said.

"Says you."

She'd have to get up soon.

She let herself indulge in the memory, feeling some shred of love and adoration for the silly little kid Adora was at the time. With her little gap in her teeth, the sparkle of those big eyes, her chubby little fingers. She wanted to protect and love the Adora of her childhood, hold her and teach her not to leave her best friends.

The one she promised she never would.

Catra felt the beginnings of a flame and rolled out of bed, accidentally crushing her tail painfully in the process. She hardly winced and grabbed her clothes. She gave the bodysuit a hard sniff to make sure it was still clean enough.

It would work.

She looked at herself in the mirror, her tired and hunched over self. Herself with her eyes alive with something resembling tired rage with a failing vessel ready to collapse at any moment.

"Ready for duty," she said sarcastically as she washed her hands and started for the door.

-

Today, she would be in charge of planning their next raid on another heavily armored town.

Civilian town.

She would get to prove herself, get to show just how capable she was. At that thought, she opened up the communication pad and tapped through its settings. She just had to contact Hordak, who refused to let anyone come into his sanctum today. Even she, Catra, second-in-command, arguably the second most important person in this damn place, wasn't allowed.

Entrapta would've been, though.

At that, she noticed she'd been crushing the communication pad a little bit, the screen straining under her claws. She relaxed her grip and brought up his name on the screen. She waited.

And waited.

And waited.

Nothing.

She growled and canceled the call, setting aside the pad and leaned back in her chair. The screens in front of her showed her all the destruction that they were causing, the victories being won in real time. She absentmindedly scrolled through each one, checking the screens for any sign of anybody real.

Specifically Scorpia, or Adora, or any of her fucking friends.

Her attention drew harder as she noticed a pair of soldiers talking to one another in the corner, one obviously flirting with the other. She hissed and shifted the screen, her thoughts suddenly consumed with the past three flings she had fucked in the last, what, week? Moons, she didn't even know anymore.

The sound of a crash outside of the structure caught her attention and she looked out the window.

Someone had knocked over one of the crates holding the ration bars for the month, scattering them everywhere.

She growled and shot out of her chair, storming out of the building.

"You!" she shouted at the unsuspecting soldier that jumped at her voice. "Come here."

The soldier looked over at her friends, fear tracing her features as she walked over as quickly as she could. "Commander Catra," she said, saluting.

Catra held a salute, dropped it, the soldier following her cue. She nodded at the spilled ration bars. “You’re in charge of cleaning those up and putting them back where they were,” she eyed the soldier, narrowed her eyes, and looked back at her face, “and see me after you’re done. I’ll be in my room.”

The soldier looked genuinely uncomfortable and seemed to hesitate, “But-”

“Is there a problem?”

“No, Commander,” the soldier said. She walked off, making her way to the ration bars.

Catra didn’t hear her clearly, but she seemed to be apologizing to her friends. She also said something that made the others look at Catra, chuckle, and pat her on the shoulders. They seemed to be smiling.

Catra bared a fang and turned around again, making her way back to the structure to watch the screens again. She settled herself in her chair, breaths heavy and quick.

What was she doing?

She glanced at the window towards the soldier cleaning up the spilled ration bars.

She was making her own happiness, that’s what. Nothing to be ashamed of. It was just stress relief. Did anyone even know how hard this was? How hard it was to constantly put on some happy face and-

“Catra.”

She looked up at the screen, Hordak on it. “Hordak.”

“Status report.”

“All is accounted for. Somebody knocked over a crate holding the ration bars. She will be given proper discipline, don’t worry,” she said.

He hummed and looked at something off-screen. “Anything else? Or am I wasting my time?”

“The town of Thaymor is still under our control. Otherwise, nothing out of the ordinary,” she said.

“Good. I have an assignment for you, Catra. Only if you want it,” he said.

Catra resisted the urge to perk her ears, refusing to show anything other than anger. “I’m listening.”

“You are to organize an attack against Bright Moon.”

“Bright Moon? The heavily guarded castle?”

“Yes. However necessary, weaken their defenses. Do not disappoint me. Then again,” he smiled, “you never have.”

The flutter in her chest at the praise was almost painful. “Of course, Lord Hordak. I won’t let you down.”

He signed off, his image disappearing from the screen.

She eyed the window again. The soldier was still working on the ration bars. She was eyeing each one and placing them into the crate with organized grace.

Catra watched her for a while, leaning in her chair.

Oh, the things she’d do tonight. The fun she’d have.

“What makes you tick, I wonder...” she mused, eyeing the soldier as she paused and looked over at Catra. They made eye contact for some time. Catra simply smiled, eyes lidded as she watched the soldier work.

Oh, the fun she'd have tonight.

-

"Amelia," she said. She read over the soldier's profile. She seemed like she'd be a decent enough soldier for this mission, maybe.

That's all this was for. I just needed her to come to my room so we can discuss it privately.

That's it.

That's it.

There was a voice at the door.

Catra sighed and stood up, walking to the door to unlock it.

She peered out of it, eyeing the hallway with narrowed eyes.

"Do you know where Commander Catra sleeps?" Amelia was asking somebody. Her helmet was off and her blond hair was showing.

Catra's breath hitched at how much she actually looked like Adora.

They almost even had the same build. Amelia was just a bit more muscular and had too few scars to be her, though.

Catra smiled.

Perfect.

"Her bedroom's just down the hall. Fourth one on the right with a giant slash mark in the door. Can't miss it," came the gruff voice of a Force Captain she didn't remember the name of, either.

"Thank you."

Catra retreated back into her room and stood behind the door.

She waited.

There was a knock and she opened the door. She forgot she was still holding the pad that had her information on it and looked over the blonde in front of her.

“Commander. You called?” she asked. She threw up a salute and held it professionally.

Catra saluted back, then dropped it, Amelia following after. “Yes, I did. Come in,” she said. She stepped aside and watched as Amelia came in. Her eyes lingered on the other woman and she found herself watching her. She traced her shoulders with her eyes, lingering on the strong muscles in her arms and back.

She looked away and shut the door, enveloping the room in darkness.

She turned on the light and sat on the bed. She held the pad in her hands, her tail flicking in a way that was almost a tell for her.

Amelia wouldn’t know it, though.

Maybe.

“I read over your profile. You seem like a-” Catra froze as Amelia almost immediately started to unbuckle her belt. “What are you doing?” she asked, stopping herself from watching as Amelia started to slide out of her pants. They pooled on the ground and she started undoing her jacket.

“Isn’t this what you wanted me in here for?” she asked. “I know your reputation, Catra. I know what you like to do with woman who come into your room alone. I know you,” she said. She slid off her jacket and Catra couldn’t breathe anymore.

“I- I mean…” she said.

Yes. Yes, I want this. I want this so bad. Moons, I want to slam her against that wall, finger her until she collapses under my

fingers.

“Isn’t this what you want?” Amelia stepped closer, clad only in her Horde-issued boxers and sports bra.

“Yes, it is,” Catra said.

Amelia sat on her lap, wrapping her arms behind Catra’s neck and holding her hands together. She stared into Catra’s eyes. “You want this, don’t you?” she asked, voice low and sultry.

She hesitated.

“Yes, I do,” she said.

Amelia smiled and leaned in.

Catra had set aside the pad ages ago, though she never remembered doing so. She had her hands at her sides, fingers knotting up the sheets. Her eyes fluttered shut.

“Then why did you hesitate?” Amelia asked, having shifted her path to whisper it into her ear instead.

Catra froze in place. “I-”

“You don’t really want to do this, do you?” Amelia said.

Catra opened her eyes again and Amelia had leaned back. She had taken off her bra and her underwear. Catra gulped and looked away. Amelia held her face and drew her in so their faces were inches apart.

“You want to feel loved, don’t you? You just want,” she trailed a finger down Catra’s keyhole, running a finger through the soft fur on her chest, “to feel important and loved. Like you mean something. Don’t you?”

“Amelia,” Catra whispered, “what are you doing?”

“Just telling you the truth,” she said. She started to grind herself against Catra’s leg. She leaned her face forward and moaned sharply into her ear.

Catra’s breath hitched and she wrapped her arms around the woman with fervor. Her body worked on impulse. It was just following the same routine it had been for the past, what, month now? She bit down on Amelia’s neck, holding her in place as she ran her claws down her back.

Amelia ground herself against her leg again and she bit down on Catra’s shoulder, moving her hands so they pressed against her chest. She shoved her against the bed.

Catra gasped and watched as she moved her hand down Catra’s chest again.

Her silence was almost painful.

“Say my name, beg for me,” Catra said, almost begging.

“And if I don’t?” she asked.

Catra shot her hands forward and swiftly tugged her down so their chests pressed together. She growled into her ear, “Then I’ll teach you what happens when you go against my commands.” She let go when Amelia tensed up, not wanting to make her too scared or uncomfortable.

Amelia hummed and started her path down.

Wait.

Catra’s fingers dug into the sheets as Amelia started going further down. She trailed her hands down her chest and sides. Catra could feel her hands even through her bodysuit and she bucked her hips.

“Needy, are we?” she clutched her hips roughly.

Catra's claws dug into the sheets, "Fuck-"

"Take this off," Amelia smiled, "now."

Catra all but obliged, scrambling to take it off in a flurry.

Amelia was laughing. Laughing at her.

"Shut the fuck up," Catra said.

Amelia said nothing, only pulling down the bodysuit so it fell to the floor with a soft thump.

Catra's chest heaved as Amelia went down, further, further. She kept eye contact as she kissed the inside of her thighs.

"Tell me, Catra…" she started, "what it feels like to lose control."

Her lips touched her and Catra gasped.

Her words reverberated through her mind, through her body, as Amelia went to work. Her tongue doing wonders. How did she learn that? Where did she learn that?

Her fingers knotted and tugged at Amelia's hair, earning her a moan from the other woman.

Her hips rocked, ground against the woman's face. She screwed her eyes shut and mewled, gritting her teeth at the disgusting noises she was making. She hated it, hated how Amelia was able to do this to her. How she made her lose herself like she was some fucking toy. Like this was all just some game, another day for her. What kind of sick trick was this?

"Mierda!" she cried, grinding against her again. It built up, it built up higher and higher. She felt herself getting closer, but never able to actually tip over.

How long had it been? How long had they been in this room together?

“Díos de cielo! Fuck!” she looked into the eyes of the other woman and hissed, “Vete a la chingada.”

Amelia smiled and, with a flurry of licks, Catra lost herself.

She gasped and wheezed, trying to catch her breath, bucking and rolling her hips desperately.

“Vete al infierno!” she cried.

Finally, relief.

She crumpled in a heap, a panting, disgusting heap. She whimpered, her tail had been thrashing around, finally relaxing.

The sound of clothes being put on.

Catra looked up through lidded eyes. “Amelia?” she asked, voice small.

“I don’t love you. I never have, never will,” she said. She leaned forward and placed a small kiss on her nose, “And Adora never did, either.”

Chapter End Notes

> How was that for fucked up? Anyway, next chapter we get to see Catra going on that very important mission. Whatever will happen? Ah'll give you a hint: twenty people and a force captain get vibe checked and a tank has a Bad Time.
> Also if my Portuguese or Spanish is inaccurate in any way, please don't hesitate to correct me! Ahm still learning it.
> Method writing, am I right?
> Anyway, have a good rest of today!

Low Valleys

Chapter Summary

> After the events of last week, Catra hasn't stopped seeing Amelia everywhere she goes. This has lead to some encouragement of some negative beliefs.
> Today is the day of the mission to attack Bright Moon's supply camp.
> Catra breaks.

Chapter Notes

> Damn okay, here we go again I guess. Thank you all for reading my last couple of chapters! I appreciate it. Anywho, get ready, get set, prepare yourselves for the beauty that is the violence part 1 of this fic haha. Oh, God.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The day had come. Catra ran a clawed hand through her hair, looking at herself in the mirror again to make sure everything was as it should be.

Everything was under control.

She turned around and started for the door again. The events of last week crept up to her, whispering in her ear. Her tail twitched and she growled, unlocking the door and exiting the room. She was greeted by the empty hallway.

Too early for anyone to be walking around.

She couldn’t sleep though. When could she ever?

She dropped onto all fours and ran through the hallway, footsteps thudding and echoing against the empty walls. She skidded and went off to the right. Entering through a door, she came into the kitchen.

She stood back up onto her legs and lazily walked in. She just needed a snack, something to pick her up before she'd go back to sleep and wake up in…

She eyed the clock.

6 hours.

The kitchen was empty. She had the entire place memorized, though, from her days in the past of raiding the kitchen for food.

She ransacked the fridges, taking out various foods and shutting the door softly behind her.

She started her run to her room again, feet hitting the floor with soft thuds that echoed through the halls.

There, her room.

She eyed the door for a moment, taking it in.

There was a large, heavy gash in the metal, four perfectly long and jagged claw marks that covered nearly the entire thing. She remembered making them. She had been stressed that day and scratched the door because it wasn't opening right.

She huffed and opened the door, tapping in her passcode with a clawed finger and slipped into her room with a silent thud of the doors behind her. She locked it behind her and crouched onto the floor next to her bed.

Her room was devoid of anything. There was the bed, the mirror, the sink, the basic features of one's private room given your status. Hers happened to have access to a small window outside.

While she ate some cold steak as fast as possible, she eyed the moons outside. They hovered in the starless sky. Adora had always talked about the stars, or at least what they could've been.

She felt a ghost of a touch against her cheek and pictured her freckles scattered across them.

She sighed and returned to eating again. Each bite was tasteless despite how flavorful each bite was. The steak, in theory, should've been good. It was already cooked, thank the moons, but still. It could've at least *tried* to taste good, you know?

She started her next attack on the soup, still cold, as everything was. Thick and creamy and moons' light it tasted like fucking dirt and cardboard.

There was a sound outside her window and she jerked her head to face it. Mouth paused in its eating, she stared out it.

She swallowed her bite and, in the softest voice she could muster, asked the darkness, "Adora?"

Laughter.

She shot to her feet. "Adora! You came back! I knew you-" she looked out the window, seeing only the twenty-foot drop to the bottom of the next floor down.

She growled and turned away from the window.

Appetite suddenly gone, she smuggled the rest of the cold food into the drawer of her dresser and stripped to her undergarments again. She lay in bed, eyeing her bodysuit.

She'd have to clean it sometime.

She sniffed the air and wrinkled her nose.

Dear moons. Is that coming from me?

She sniffed her arm experimentally and hissed.

Definitely was.

She grumbled and rolled over in bed.

Tomorrow, when it was morning again, she'd shower. It would have to do.

She shut her eyes, exhaustion creeping in.

Sometimes that meant her nightmares wouldn't plague her. She'd find out soon, wouldn't she?

She would, soon enough.

-

Adora and Catra were running through the halls. Catra bounded beside her as they ran around.

"You're going so slow! Can't you go faster?" Catra asked with a groan. She had slowed down to a semi-trot on all fours, smiling at the other child who was panting as she ran at what seemed like max exertion.

"I totally could! I just...gotta...push...harder," Adora said between wheezes.

"Run on your hands too! It's more comfortable!" Catra said. She watched as Adora dropped to all fours and almost immediately collapsed into a heap. "Woah. You okay?" she asked, stopping. She sat down next to her and sniffed her unmoving body. "Are you dead?"

"No. Just tired," Adora said, words muffled by the floor.

"Slowpoke. Come on, get up. Try it on your hands and feet this time!" Catra demonstrated by easily walking around on all fours. Her legs were bent almost to the ground and her spine was parallel to the floor. "See! Not hard. You try!"

Adora groaned and pushed herself up. She got onto all fours and good moons her posture was *terrible* .

Catra shook her head and showed her, “No! You’re doing it wrong! See just- bend your knees like this.” She showed her again and walked forward and turned around. “Like that.”

Adora tried to adjust herself and her posture looked better that time. She was shaking in the legs. “Ow, my legs hurt.”

“That’s ‘cause you haven’t been doing it long enough! Just keep-“

Adora collapsed again and groaned into the floor. “I can’t do it...”

“Yes you can! Just keep-“

Adora was starting to cry, “ *Catra! I can’t do it!* “ She was sobbing now, having rolled onto her side and clutching her knees.

“No, no! It’s okay! You don’t have to do it. You can walk on your legs, it’s okay,” Catra said. She lay down on the floor next to her and snuggled up so her head was pressed against her chest, exposing her mane of hair to her.

Adora softly started to scritch her head, sobbing and sniffling into her mane. She cuddled with her head and continued to cry with shaky breaths.

Catra started to purr, eyes shutting at the scritches. She pushed her head into Adora’s hands and rubbed her cheek against her jaw.

“You got spit on me, Catra,” Adora said, voice wavering but she could hear her smiling.

Catra paused, then proceeded to do it again, harder, so that Adora’s jaw was covered in spit.

My friend! Nobody else’s friend! My Adora! My Adora! My Adora!

Adora was giggling and roughly scratched Catra’s mane.

Catra rolled around, purrs growing louder. She was purring hard enough to make tiny trills with it, eyes shut and body swaying a bit. Her tail thrashed a little bit as it started to get a bit much.

Adora stopped.

Catra kept purring. “Why’d you stop?” she asked, cracking open an eye to look at the snot-covered Adora.

“Your tail was going whoosh-whoosh in the air and I didn’t want you to bite or scratch me again,” she said.

Catra shrugged, “Yeah, okay.” She got to her feet, rubbing the paw pads on her hands. The pads on them were cracking a little bit and stung.

“Oh. Does that hurt?” Adora asked.

“Yeah...” Catra mumbled.

“It’s okay. I’ll get you some medicine for it!” Adora wiped her snot and the scene got a bit darker.

The lights were starting to dim and Adora’s voice echoed.

“I’ll be right back!”

“Adora?” Catra called as she started to run off.

“Right back...” her voice echoed, continuing to ricochet off of the empty hall’s walls.

“Adora! Wait!” Catra called, suddenly growing taller with each step as Adora disappeared into the darkness. “Adora! Come back!” She kept running down the hall, watching as it got longer and longer. It never stopped extending, Adora’s distant figure seemingly hidden in the shadows getting further from her. “Adora!” she cried out.

Fear laced her chest, her body shook.

She was abandoning her, leaving her behind just like everyone else did. Just like she always would.

Catra fell to her knees, older, her body covered in scars from Shadow Weaver's training over the years. She held her arms tight enough to leave angry imprints that lingered on her skin. She shook as the room got colder and colder, darker, then lighter.

Lighter, lighter.

Screaming.

Catra started to scream, joining the cries of whoever else was screaming in the dream with her.

-

She woke up to the sound of sirens.

"Fire in wing A-14! All units in A-14 evacuate immediately! Fire in wing A-14!" came a voice over the speaker.

She pressed her face into the pillow and groaned. She wasn't in that unit, thank the moons.

What dumbass started a fire?

Catra looked at the clock and sighed.

Two more hours until the day would start. Knowing the alarms, though, that's more like right about now.

She lay on her back on the bed and stared at the ceiling. The voice over the speaker continued to blare and she listened to it until it became an empty drone. It stopped at last and she got up. She put on her bodysuit, dirty as it was, and grabbed some fresh pajamas.

She'd ask for a new uniform after she was done.

-

She turned on the water and gave herself a rinse. Holding the soap in her hand, she frantically scrubbed all her creases as fast as she possibly could. She put the soap away and cleaned her hair as fast as she could, turning on the water again to rinse herself off. In less than three minutes, it was done.

She shook herself out, mane poofing up a bit. She grabbed her towel and dried herself off as fast as she could, not wanting to waste any more time in this humid and wet room if she could.

Besides, the sandals were bothering her.

She left the room dressed in clean pajamas and went back to her room again. She waited in the cold room, watching the time as she waited for her clothes to finish being cleaned. With a huff, she lay back down on the bed and stared at the ceiling.

The room stank of sex and her own body odor.

She eyed the window, feeling everything start to hit again.

What Amelia had said to her…

She remembered passing by her in the hall. Whenever she was with her friends, she only looked at her with glimmering eyes.

But when they were alone…

She shut her eyes and tried to force her last interaction with her out of her head.

It didn't help.

The voice droned on.

-

"Hey, kitty," Amelia said. She had on a wicked smile.

"What do you want?" Catra asked. She narrowed her eyes and snarled. "Another round or something?"

She laughed and shook her head. "Oh, kitty. You're a mess. You really do need to work on yourself. Maybe after this mission you'll finally feel important," Amelia looked at her, "maybe you'll feel special."

Catra growled and lunged for her. Amelia grabbed her by the wrist and smiled.

"Maybe you should go to sleep. You know that everyone's whispering about your eyebags. Also..." she looked at her hair and gently tucked a stray strand behind her jaw, "you really should smooth your hair down again. It's getting a bit too wild."

Catra froze as Amelia let her go and walked off with a wave. She stood there, tears pricking at the corners of her eyes.

Why was this bothering her so much?

Why did she want to tell her she loved her? Would that make her stay?

-

Catra felt tears run down her face and spun around so she planted her face into the pillow. She groaned into it and sat back up. Her hair had left a water stain on the pillow and she shook her head out again. It was starting to dry a bit but was still fairly wet as of right now.

She stood up and walked to the mirror.

Its surface was marred by tiny scratches, handprints, what looked like droplets of water or soap or something else on it. She eyed the clock again.

Her clothes were probably clean by now.

The day was starting.

Her hair was drying.

She looked at her reflection, smoothed her hair down, and hissed at it. “Cabrón.”

-

The day started with her heart beating quick in her chest as she rode the tank to the supply loading site of Bright Moon.

They’d chosen a time when their defenses were at their lowest. All their energy and attention was diverted and focused on an internal conflict about some massive superweapon that she’d heard from the vine.

The moons were out, faintly dimming the land in darkness as she advanced towards the supplies. Nobody was guarding it, strangely enough.

Not strangely, actually. It was fairly common for them, with such a large kingdom, to leave so few guards and proper defenses to protect their supplies and land. Besides, they were a bit busy with the second fleet going for the castle to distract them anyway.

“Commander Catra,” came a voice from her badge.

“What is it?” Catra asked, watching as the tanks started to make their descent towards the hill where the supply camp hid nestled between the valley.

“There’s a bit of a problem with one of the tanks. We need to turn back and do repairs,” they said.

Catra eyed the supplies. Her breathing was faster. She was so close. Did they really think she’d turn back and retreat just for one tank? So many soldiers were fighting over in Bright Moon’s territory. “Can’t you stop and fix it yourself?” she asked, voice getting slightly clipped.

“We’re unit 16.”

Shit. How did she not notice that the vital fucking unit was damaged?

"Case still stands. You can fix it yourself while we advance," she said, gritting her teeth.

"We have to turn back."

"Are you questioning my orders?" she asked.

Silence.

"Well?"

Silence.

Catra felt fury rise into her. She hadn't slept right for weeks, she was so fucking tired of this. How did she not realize she fucking failed? What in the moons was wrong with her?

"Commander?"

"Keep going! We're almost there!" she said.

She watched the tank ahead of her, Unit 16. It seemed to stutter a bit in place, shifting around. Its tread was worn a bit and it looked like it was leaking oil.

How could she possibly be such a fucking idiot? She couldn't turn back. She couldn't turn back now. No. No, she had to keep going. People were dying, people were depending on her. She had to keep going.

They were so close.

The tank stopped in place with a loud crash.

Catra jerked forward as her tank slammed into the one in front of her. Her head slammed against the console and she hissed, rubbing it.

“Unit 16! Re-“

A blast reverberated through the air. She scampered out of the tank, lifting up the hatch.

In front of her, the tank had failed, the heat of the engine having ignited the fuel and blown it up.

Next to it, the other tanks were starting to fail, too.

“Get out of there!” she cried into her radio.

Hatches opened, people’s hands and heads emerging.

Smoking from nearby tanks.

Failing.

The valley around them was too steep and the tanks kept rolling, taking everyone inside with it.

“Get out of there! Now!”

Nobody was moving fast enough. She ripped out the soldier driving her tank and tossed her aside and out of harm’s way. She sprung to the nearest one, ready to rip them out too.

When she opened the hatch, a cloud of black smoke billowed out, choking her senses.

Fire, heat.

She coughed and turned away, trying to get off of it before anything else could happen.

Nothing worked.

Nothing was working.

Soldiers, good ones, were screaming and crying out as they burned alive and their tanks quickly started to fail. They kept

barrelling towards the supply camp, taking the soldiers who couldn't escape in time with them.

Catra leaped out, making sure everyone who did make it out alive got out of the way before they could get run over.

She dodged frantically out of the way of several tanks that came rolling unpredictably down the hillside. Everything smelled of smoke and burned flesh, the screams of soldiers echoed almost soundlessly in her ears. Sounds of singeing metals and sickening smells, almost sweet, masked and yet detectable under the smells of flesh and death that filled her nose.

She gagged and ran off.

Once she was safely out of the danger zone, she shouted an, "Everyone to me!"

Soldiers who had escaped from the mayhem crowded around her.

"Role call!" she shouted, trying to hide the anger in her voice at her own incompetence, the one that got so many fucking soldiers killed.

There was a force captain in there, wasn't there?

"Fuck."

She barely heard everyone calling their name, had to keep her voice from shaking, had to stop herself.

The sounds of approaching footsteps, heavy and animalistic.

"Hide!"

She saw them all scatter, all hiding away.

Then she heard more screaming.

The world was spinning around her as she hid in the brush of the Whispering Woods. She heard the sounds of animals screeching

and whooping with their kills, the sound of destruction happening.

This was all her fault.

She had failed.

And she got everybody killed in the process.

-

She started her trek on foot back to the Horde after she knew it was all clear. Her hands had been burnt by the hatch, too hot from the internal flames cooking those inside of it; her body mangled and bruised and scratched both from tree branches. thorns, and the effort of running back to the base.

Failure, failure, failure.

The tears came again as she covered little distance over time.

She didn't know how long she had been walking until she finally collapsed in the woods, tired, spent, exhausted.

The world blurred and spun, the moons shining overhead as she lay in the dirt. Her eyes shut, her chest heaved, and sleep took her with clawed fingers.

She woke up from a dreamless sleep to the sound of a crash nearby.

She tensed up, frozen in place, listening.

More crackling, snapping.

Footsteps heavy and thick.

She stilled her breathing, keeping her cool in active combat.

She unsheathed her claws and got up on shaky knees, crawling behind a tree. She pressed her back against it and glanced around it.

An animal, some sort of giant...bug-eyed creature.

It reminded her of the one that chased her in the temple with Adora.

Adora.

She growled, alerting the animal, who shrieked in alarm and charged her.

She was too tired, too hurt, she wouldn't win this time.

She ran off, climbing the tree and hopping between them until she was away from the creature.

She looked back, breaths shallow and shaky.

It had vanished.

She hissed and climbed back down, making her way to the Horde that she could see billowing smoke in the distance.

Failure.

She had failed.

Nobody had tried to contact her yet, but she did send out a distress signal with a push of her badge. Exhausted again at the edge of the woods, she collapsed into a heap of soaked skin and clumped fur.

Her whole body hurt and by the moons…

I almost died.

She realized that now. Looking back, she had almost died. She'd willingly got out of the tank and launched herself like a fucking dumbass at a blazing tank billowing with smoke. She'd almost been run over twice.

"I almost died," she said.

The sound of a skiff was coming, but she blacked out from exhaustion before she could see who was on it.

-

She woke up in an isolation room, a jail cell. She looked at the cuffs on her hands, tugged a bit on them before wincing at the pain of her tired joints.

"¡Mierda!" she shouted into the cell. She kicked the wall and lay on the floor, staring at the ceiling.

Waiting for her trial.

Waiting to see what Hordak would do to her.

-

The days seemed to pass so slowly as she lay inside of the cell. She scratched a line into the wall, marking the fourth day.

She sat, holding her legs and stared at the wall.

I almost died. I killed dozens of people, good people, good soldiers.

She thought this to herself, an empty drone, until someone stopped by with food for her.

She twitched an ear and looked up. In the darkness of the main room, she couldn't see exactly who it was that was serving her food.

Nor did she really want to.

"Hey, Catra,"

She rolled her eyes, "Oh, it's you. What? Come to berate me some more? Fuck me senseless while I'm all tied up like this?"

Amelia laughed, a solid one that sounded so weird coming from her. She was so...nervous at first. What changed? “Maybe later. Right now I’m giving you food,” she dropped it with a clatter, “there you go. Eat up, Kitty.”

She didn’t walk away.

“What?”

“I want to make sure you eat.”

Catra sighed and scooted over, grabbing the tray and bringing it close to her. She started for the meat slop first, eating it quickly and intensely uncomfortably under Amelia’s stare.

“There. I’m eating. Can you leave now?” she asked, not hiding the hostility in her voice.

“Not yet. Keep going.”

“For fucks sake,” she leaned back and ate the rest of the food in silence, looking away from the woman who just...stood there. Her arms weren’t crossed, she didn’t look bored. She just stood there.

If anything, her body posture seemed interested.

“Okay. I’m done. Can you leave?” Catra asked.

“What? Don’t want company?”

Oh for the skies-

“Not from you.”

Catra saw her shrug and she walked off, grabbing the tray loudly. “Suit yourself, Kitty.”

The cell was quieter without her and she found herself almost missing her.

Not almost. She *did* miss her.

She sighed and bumped her head gently on the wall, pressing the back of it against the smooth, unrelenting metal. The sounds of the Horde's mechanical workings continued on as she waited.

And waited.

And waited.

She wasn't tired yet, not even close. All she wanted to do was just...talk. Or look at something more interesting than a wall. Anything, really.

But that wasn't going to happen. Not here, not now, not ever.

She looked at her hands and flexed them.

As long as she lived, she couldn't see herself doing anything but hurt others.

Her hand pads were still aching a bit despite having only burnt them four days ago. It felt weird to flex them.

She shut her hands.

She lay back.

She finally went to sleep again.

-

The nightmares didn't relent, only worsening, as she awaited her trial. Each passing day, Amelia would come to deliver her food, plus other activities they really only cared about. Sometimes, Amelia would actually stay and talk to her. Usually, it consisted of her telling her trivial things about how the sky was stormy and "Isn't that just what your head's like? So cloudy and full of anger," which royally pissed off Catra every time. Why she couldn't just...not say that was beside her in understanding.

None of it made any sense whatsoever.

One day, though, on the tenth day, Catra got bored, again.

Amelia came into the cell holding the tray of food. It was lighter and she could see her this time. Ten days into her incarceration, she was starting to lose it a bit.

Who wouldn't?

"Hey, Amelia. Good to see you again," she said, almost meaning it this time.

"Got your food. Eat up, Kitty. You don't want me to stick around if you know what's good for you," she said. She dropped her food with a clatter that hurt Catra's ears a little bit.

Catra scooted over and started eating the food. She looked up at Amelia, tail flicking a bit. "Why shouldn't I want you around?" she asked, "You're the only person that actually talks to me."

Amelia was looking through her, eyes slightly glazed over.

After a bit, Catra asked."Who hurt you?"

Amelia looked at her, eyes still empty but now focused directly on her. It was strange, seeing her sudden transformation. One moment, she was this cocky, overconfident woman that Catra remembered seeing for the past three weeks now. The next moment, she got smaller, crumpled to her knees, and started to just take deep breaths.

Catra sat there awkwardly as Amelia started crying. She didn't know what to do, really, other than just sit there. She wanted to say something, not quite comfort her though. Something was wrong but she didn't bother asking her about it.

Amelia looked at her, eyes still empty, leaned forward, and grabbed her by the cheeks, planting a hard kiss on her lips.

Catra tensed up, hands balled into fists at her sides. She waited, moving with the other woman anyway.

She didn't break the kiss, only deepening it and moving forward to climb next to her. She shoved the tray out of the way and started for her neck.

"Amelia. Why are you doing this?" she asked.

No response, just more crying. She started to suck on her neck, nibbling it in places and lapping it with her tongue.

It felt nice, sure, but why was she doing this?

She raised her hands, placed them on her shoulders, and shoved her away.

A mess of mussed hair and empty eyes, she stared back with heavy breaths. She was looking at Catra's lips and her hands were flexing a lot.

"Amelia. What's wrong?"

She didn't respond, only stared into her eyes. She wiped her own and stood up with the tray in her hands. She left, closing the holographic door and walking off in silence.

-

The trial was tomorrow.

She woke up to the sound of the lift being activated. She turned her head as the soldiers came to grab her.

They grabbed her with rough hands, undoing the cuffs and dragging her towards the throne room where Hordak would be waiting.

As they started going down the many halls and passed doors to the throne room, things felt different.

For starters, everywhere was quiet, devoid of talking or other soldiers interacting with one another. There were no bots patrolling the area, simply vanished from sight.

She heard the sounds of murmuring muffled by thick walls coming from where Hordak’s throne lay. Her stomach tightened into a knot.

The sudden memory of the things she’d done that she had all but shoved ruthlessly from her mind. Repressed it, as they would say.

It was her fault. She knew that. She knew it was her fault. She knew it was her fault that dozens of people died under her claws, that a force captain died, that many more were hurt that she neglected to check up on. Selfishly, she had run off. She never bothered to check after the animals had come to attack to see if there were any survivors.

It was her fault.

The door opened and the crowd of soldiers along the stairs and waiting around fell silent. All eyes were on her.

She swallowed thickly.

And now she was going to pay for it.

Chapter End Notes

> Hoo buddy that was a ride, huh? Anyway, Amelia isn't going to show up anymore in the rest of the fic sorry not sorry- also like- we're vibing here.
> Also, sorry but DT isn't here because their presence meant a lot of different things change in the show so no DT y'all.
> Anyhow! What's going to happen to our dear Catra now? Can I ever write anything more than four sentences per paragraph? Am I capable of writing long works? Find out next in chapter 4, Remote Hunger of Droning Things!

Remote Hunger of Droning Things

Chapter Summary

> Brand the meow-meow! Brand the meow-meow!
> Hordak orders a court-martial on Catra and decides her fate.
> (There's a scene where Hordak brands Catra's palms and declaws her near the beginning. The scars will be prevalent throughout the entire story. I wrote it so the scene itself wasn't the main focus of the story. Please read carefully)

Chapter Notes

> Sorry for being a lil bitch and not uploading anything for over two months. I had this finished since about a week or two after I posted the last chapter. I just decided not to post it because, and you guessed it, I'm a little bitch.
> Anyway, enjoy the show!!!!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“We’re gathered here so that all can witness what happens to those that turn against their own,” Hordak said, voice echoing through the room.

Catra struggled against her bonds as she was forcibly shoved into the spacious room. “Let go of me-“ she growled, getting promptly shoved to the ground.

She was dragged to the pit.

It blistered with heat, smoke curling up and choking her senses. She coughed and spat, struggling against her bonds, claws bound up in mittens of steel. “What? Are you going to burn me alive? Just send me to Beast Island, hijo de puta!” she said.

Hordak ignored her, continuing to speak to the audience gathered. They consisted mainly of younger soldiers and cadets who eyed her with wide and darting eyes.

She looked back as someone she swore she'd seen before walked out of the pit wearing thick, insulated gloves and a full protective suit. They were holding a cherry red branding rod and walking towards her.

Catra watched as they got closer and closer, each step ramping up her heart rate. She felt multiple heavy hands hold her down, cut her bodysuit so both of her arms were fully exposed.

They pinned her down, knees on her back, and hands twisting hers so her palms faced skyward. They held her fingers painfully down, nearly breaking them as they slammed heavy boots onto her fingers to hold them in place.

She'd never seen this happen, never heard of this.

She didn't have time to think.

All she could feel was blistering pain singe her palms.

She let out a scream as the smell of burning flesh filled her nostrils. Every cell in her body screamed and she stiffened up, heart pounding and breathing heavy.

Her palms burned to hell and back.

She didn't register the grinding sound of the drill or the pain as her claws were ground down to stumps, blood trickling from declawed fingers.

All she felt was numb.

And then it was done.

The weights lifted off of her, the room spun despite her laying on the floor. She shut her eyes at the sound of Hordak's voice, not even strong enough to say anything insulting to that bastard.

All she could do was lay there as the crowd murmured amongst themselves.

“Dismissed.”

The room fell silent.

Heavy hands grabbed her and dragged her limp and frozen body to an isolation room where she was dropped off and shut in.

Darkness.

And then the pain kicked in and the world flooded back.

She screamed a scream she’d never screamed before.

Her throat tore itself raw. Free of her bonds, she scrambled to her feet, not able to see even in the darkness of the room with her glowing eyes. Her breaths came out shallow as she scrambled to her shaky feet and pounded on the walls with half-closed fists. “Let me out! Let me the fuck out!” she cried.

The pain kicked in again.

She doubled over, unable to breathe, everything hurting and aching and sore. She gagged and nothing came up, just choked and heavy sobs. She didn’t dare feel her palms, knowing something had been done to them but didn’t know what. All she knew was that it hurt...bad.

When she curled in her fingers, she felt pain.

Touching her fingertips hurt.

Everything hurt.

Moons in the sky, everything hurt so bad

She lay on the wall, energy depleted. For once in her life, she felt completely defenseless. Without her claws…

She felt her fingertips, trying to find the claws, only finding the stumps of what once were formidable talons fit for fighting. It was sticky and smelled metallic. Nothing could have prepared her for

the twang of pain that came with her even lightly brushing the pad of her finger against the wounds. Any attempt to sheathe claws that weren't there in her hand pads made her fingers hurt in a way they weren't supposed to.

All of this was wrong.

This was wrong.

She couldn't protect herself.

She was helpless.

Weak.

She rested her head on the wall, sobbing hard. She couldn't ball her hands into fists right now, only able to simply sit there with them spread out in a way that wasn't exceedingly painful. Every time they stretched or flexed it burnt and stung.

Shadow Weaver was right.

She was useless after all.

She finally lay down and slept, unable to do much else.

-

Day 1

-

Catra's hands were burning again and she gritted her teeth to avoid whimpering against the pain.

The door opened.

She shot to her feet, hands spread and fingers instinctively flexing to unsheathe claws that were no longer there. She hissed and winced again, gritting her teeth as she bent over in response to the pain that flooded through her.

The guard came in holding medical supplies. She walked in with heavy steps and protective gear. The room had smelled of some sort of cleaning product she hadn't noticed in her shock until now. She glared at the guard.

"What do you want? Come here to belittle me some more?" she asked.

"I'm here to dress your brands," she said simply, sitting across from her. She started opening up the supplies and grabbing out the necessary ointments. "Now sit here so I can help."

"Fuck you," Catra spat.

The guard eyed her and shrugged, "Suit yourself." She stood up again and walked out of the room, shutting the door behind her and leaving the medical supplies in the dark room.

"Wait-" Catra cursed as the door closed and sat down blindly in front of the medical supplies. She leaned forward and sniffed them, feeling for them with the backs of her fingers and hands.

Finding gauze, a tube of something, and some sort of container. She grumbled and struggled to open the tube, hissing with each flex of her hands. Whatever they'd done to her palms hurt like a *madre* .

She wrapped her hands shakily in the gauze after putting on the cream and gel. It soothed the wounds on her palms and she experimentally flexed her hands, wincing at the pain.

The next time she saw Hordak she was going to fucking kill him.

She didn't know exactly how she would now that she didn't exactly have claws.

But she would.

She'd kill him somehow.

“Bastard,” she grumbled as she lay on the floor again. She stared into the darkness, listening for anything outside of her own breathing and heartbeat.

Voices.

She swiveled an ear and looked over towards the door. The voices were too muffled to make out, but they were talking about her.

That is, she thought they were. She didn’t really know. She didn’t know anything right now, did she?

She sighed and shut her eyes, letting herself go to sleep again.

-

She woke up maybe an hour later after somebody knocked on the door. She groaned and looked over. “What?” she asked.

“You were screaming in your sleep,” the guard said. She sounded worried for her.

She didn’t know who it was but didn’t bother asking. “Cool. I’m going back to sleep.”

A grunt and footsteps.

She thought as she crossed her arms, sniffing the air. She could smell the smell of medicine, whatever medicine that was supposed to accelerate the healing of whatever they did to her hands.

Didn’t she say they branded her?

She wrinkled her nose and scowled.

Disgusting.

She flexed her hands and promptly hissed in pain, letting her palms relax so as not to aggravate them too much. She sighed

and curled up on the floor, shutting her eyes again in the pitch darkness.

Soon...she'd be free...whatever they would do to her, she'd survive.

She wrinkled her nose at a smell and sniffed herself again.

No dice.

She sighed and wrinkled her nose.

Oh, so now her fucking *breath* stank?

"Hey!" she called out.

No response.

She stood up and kicked the door, "Hey!"

No response.

She kicked it again.

"Oh for- what?" came a voice behind it.

"What time is it?"

"Four-thirty in the morning. I thought you were going to sleep?"

"Yeah, yeah, I will. Can I brush my teeth?"

Silence. "Are you sure that's a good idea?" they asked, voice gentle.

"What?"

"Your hands..."

Her palms *did* really hurt…

“What...what did you do to them?”

A pause. “I didn’t want to. Hordak ordered me to brand you. They should feel better in a couple of days once you keep it clean, put on the ointment. Just keep it up. I want you to leave.”

“Oh. So you were the bitch that branded me?” she asked, kicking the door, “You were the motherfucker to do it?”

“I didn’t want to. Go the fuck to sleep.”

“Go fuck yourself,” Catra said.

She walked off to the back of the room and felt around. She stumbled around, finding a sink, a shower, a toilet, and what felt like a bed. She lay down on its hard surface, covering herself in the blanket.

She’d deal with her personal hygiene later. It wasn’t like she hadn’t gone some days without showering. She shut her eyes, started to lick her arm, and lulled herself to sleep.

-

A knock.

“What?” she asked groggily, narrowing her eyes in the direction of the door.

“Medicine.”

She groaned and got out of bed, shuffling to the door and sitting on the floor. She blinked as her eyes adjusted to the sudden light.

“Oh, it’s you,” she said under her breath.

“Yeah. It’s me,” Persephone said. She sat down and put the medical supplies in front of her. “Are you going to be unreasonable again or can I dress your wounds this time?” she asked.

Catra opened her mouth, ready to snap again. She paused and grumbled a "Dress my wounds this time, please."

Persephone was quiet as she held out a hand.

Catra complied. In the light, she could see what was branded on her palms that stung when she stretched them open.

Persephone started unwrapping the gauze and squeezed on the ointment in silence.

"I'm...I'm sorry," Catra said softly.

"For what?"

"For, y'know..." Catra hesitated. She didn't want to say it.

"Be specific."

She didn't want to say it.

So she said it anyway

"For pushing you away after we fucked," Catra said, a mumble. She looked at what was branded on her palms.

The Horde insignia. It was glaringly obvious, the marks ragged and angry. It seemed to laugh at her, marking her permanently as a failure, an absolute disgrace.

Then she covered it and it was gone. "It's fine. I knew you'd do that, anyway."

Catra felt genuinely hurt by that and looked away. Hurt was quickly replaced with anger and she whipped her hand back to her side and held out the other. She growled, "Can you hurry up?"

"No. I have to make sure they aren't infected," Persephone said.

Catra grumbled as the gauze was removed and she spread the ointment on her palms.

“Good. Healing well. Give it a couple more days. You’ll be gone before you know it,” she said.

“What? Are they going to knock me out and send me to die?”

“Something like that. I don’t know the specifics,”

Catra watched as her other hand was dressed and drew her hand to her chest. “Thanks,” she mumbled.

“Yeah. It’s cool.”

Persephone stood up, took the supplies with her, and walked off wordlessly. She shut the door and Catra felt a heaviness wash over her again.

She was alone. Everyone had left her, again.

First, Adora, Scorpia, Amelia, now Persephone.

Who’s next?

She thought back to all her flings and winced. So many. Would they all come to help her or would it only be Persephone?

She walked back to the cot and lay down again, sighing and shutting her eyes. The room spun a bit and she rolled around in bed for some time before finally going to sleep again.

-

Persephone was the one to dress her wounds again, neither wanting to talk to one another as they worked. Persephone would change her dressings, give her food, finally gave her some toothpaste and a toothbrush for her to clean herself on the last day of her incarceration.

“Hey, Catra,” came her voice.

“Hey, Persephone,” Catra said back.

“It’s time to go.”

“I’m going to go free?” Catra asked.

“Yes. Yes, you are. Last meal before you go, though,” she said.

Catra sat down in front of her tray of food and started eating it. As she got to the drink, she chugged it down.

It tasted...weird.

“What’s...what’s in this?” Catra asked. She looked at her empty glass.

“There wasn’t anything in it. Come on, let’s get you going,” Persephone said.

Catra frowned and stood up. She walked after Persephone, noticing she was staying awfully close to her.

Catra’s eyes were getting a bit heavy. She noticed she was a bit dizzy, too. She clutched her head with an aching hand and took a deep breath. She kept walking, noticing it was a bit more sluggish and a bit harder to move. Now that she noticed, it was a bit harder to do anything, really.

She also noticed her vision blurring a bit, things feeling...weird.

Relaxing, but weird nonetheless.

She didn’t notice herself crumple to her knees as she got onto the lift, nor felt herself being carried by Persephone.

She couldn’t move, couldn’t do anything, only feeling...sluggish, tired.

So, so tired…

-

She woke up in the middle of the desert at night. It was so fucking cold. She looked down and noticed she had been dressed in a loose long shirt with cropped sleeves and a pair of long and breezy pants too.

"What the fuck?" she asked, feeling disoriented, dizzy, and moons so fucking tired.

She was also in a small tent. She didn't know where, or what, or when, but all she knew was she was tired and surrounded by unfamiliar things.

And that she felt really sick and absolutely terrible.

She groaned and lay on her side, clutching her stomach and shutting her eyes to try and keep the room from spinning so goddamn much.

She'd figure it out later, whatever the moons happened.

She'd figure it out later.

She'd figure out what happened later.

Chapter End Notes

> Disclaimer: Nothing happened to Catra other than her clothes being changed while she was unconscious and thrown off a skiff. She is alright otherwise.
> How fun is that? Brand the meow-meow! Brand her and abandon her in the middle of the desert yeeeee!!!!!!

The Great Silence

Chapter Summary

> Catra gets high off a plant and vividly hallucinates, almost dies three separate times.
> Also, there's Adora there, too.
> When did she show up?
> FLESH, FLESH, FLESH!!!!!

Chapter Notes

> Hey, y'all! I'm here, I'm queer, and I've been writing this for literal months because I have the procrastination skills of a king. Literally, everyone, I did everything but write this fic for the entirety of the waiting period. I'm glad so many of you like it though! Thanks!
> Anyway, yeah so there's weird blood at the end, some mentions of Catra's flings, also Scorpia gets viciously attacked by Catra because we don't have DT here to vibe check her so goddamnit looks like she'll have to die to develop, huh?
> Anyway, enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Okay, first things first. Where the fuck was she?

The Crimson Waste.

She'd been here before. Two years ago. She'd survived then. She could survive now.

She started off by first taking in her surroundings the day after she had slept off her hangover. She'd been given a tent, a firestarter, a folding knife, a small axe, a sleeping bag, some rations, a canteen of water, and a small toolkit.

Honestly, it was a luxury. Did they really think she was going to die if she had all this with her?

She felt for her hair, slicked back, and only found close-cut shaved hair in its place. She growled and looked at the ground. Her chest heaved with each breath.

Still weak.

Still dizzy.

A sandstorm was kicking up.

She needed to close up the tent if she were to survive it.

She scrambled to the opening and shut it with shaky fingers. The winds were whipping the material around wildly. Everything was getting sand in her eyes and everything was absolutely fucking terrible.

She lay down on the floor of the tent after closing it.

She shut her eyes.

She took a deep breath.

And screamed her rage into the heavens.

-

She was hungry.

She went through the pack and took out one of the ration bars. It was the grey kind, luckily. She took a bite of it, ignoring how bad it tasted despite the color.

The winds were whipping outside of the tent and she sighed. It was hot inside of the tent, so hot and dry and terrible. She looked at her hands and her paw pads. The Horde insignia glared at her, hurting every time she stretched or curled her hands into a fist.

The floor of the tent was comfortable against her back as she lay down on it. She shut her eyes and sighed deeply, letting herself relax for a moment.

I'll be okay. I just need to get to that place. That bar. I can find my way after that. I'll be fine.

She rolled onto her side and curled up, holding her tail and letting herself be comfortable again. Out here, she was safe, she wasn't in any danger except the dangers of the Crimson Waste. Other than that? She was safe.

Alone.

But safe.

She tried not to think about her being alone for too long. At the Horde, she was never really alone. She had Adora growing up, then she had her squadron, then she had Scorpia, then all her flings...

Persephone...

She had looked the most like Adora, just...her voice was a bit too deep and she had different features.

She rubbed the tip of her tail and realized.

She didn't remember what anyone else but Adora looked like.

Maybe Scorpia, but even her image was fuzzy at best in her mind.

The winds whipped around the tent. Outside, the brighter moons were nearly at their peaks. Only 4 of the eight that needed to be up were up right now. Given another...10 hours or so they'd all go down and she'd have to deal with the Crimson Waste at nighttime. She didn't exactly know too well what that'd look like, though. All she remembered from the last time she was here was that it got cold. Really, really cold. It was bone-chillingly cold at night time and would stay that way until the moons came up again about 13 hours later to start the daytime cycle anew.

She sighed and tried to think of all her training.

They knew next to nothing about the Crimson Waste since it didn't have much value in terms of land. It was full of venomous animals, deadly plants, and other things that would kill her.

"Fantastic," she said. She sat up and rummaged through her supply kit to see what exactly they'd provided for her there.

Oh, wow. They'd packed her a lensatic compass and a piece of paper.

Great.

She looked over the compass, opening it up and looked over the parts. She peered through the sight, adjusted the bevel, and messed around some more with it. There was also a small pad of paper, but that was really it.

At least they gave me a knife and a firestarter.

The note was an instruction guide on using the supplies she was given.

As if she didn't know how to use them.

Plus also a thick stack of shitty paper, possibly for mapmaking. How useful.

She set the note and paper aside and grabbed the compass. She stretched the lanyard and wrapped it snugly around her neck, sighing. She opened up the compass again and watched the needle promptly freak the ever-loving fuck out. She turned it to and fro, watching the needle move around.

Finally, it was still.

She sat up and sat with her back hunched, crossing her legs, watching the compass move as she moved it around.

North.

She consulted her natural sense of direction, wishing it were more accurate and could better guide her to that bar.

Her natural sense of direction said the bar would be about...a really far distance away. 300 miles? Maybe more...

She couldn't tell, too fuzzy, probably more than 300 in that case. That would be about...3 weeks of walking? Not including breaks, moving each dawn, dusk, and the more manageable times of the day.

Moons, too goddamn long.

The wind howling outside reminded her that today would have to be a rest day.

-

There wasn't much to do in the Crimson Waste right now.

All she could do was sit or lay on the floor and wait for the storm to pass.

In a sense, being alone gave her some time to reflect. Maybe that's what they wanted her to do out here.

Reflect.

Hordak's words echoing in her head told her otherwise, though.

As time passed and she lay on the floor, all she could do was think, and think, and think some more.

She first thought of how pissed she was at Hordak, at everybody, at everything.

Then, she thought of how sad she was that she was upset again, that she was alone again.

Her mind started to wander as the sandstorm outside raged on. How long had it been going on for?

She started to remember.

Scorpia.

She remembered Scorpia again.

-

"We're losing. We're losing and you don't even care!" Catra said. She clenched her fists and huffed, gritting her teeth. "We've been losing ground again since the Rebellion took the ship," she looked down. Scorpia was holding something, a cup in her hands. "What's that?"

"Oh!" Scorpia, who still looked concerned, was now looking into the cup, "I made some tea. Family recipe. I thought you would want some since, you know, it's been kind of stressful for you lately and—"

Catra hissed and swiped it out of her hands, drinking it in one gulp. "Great. Tasted great. So can you get the recordings or am I wasting my time?"

"Yeah! Yeah, sure. I can try. It's just...I don't know where they'd be at all."

Catra's patience was starting to run lower by the minute, "Then figure it out."

Scorpia's expression changed again, "Right! Right, totally. I can do that. I'll be right back."

She walked off at a brisk pace and Catra sighed. She ran a hand through her hair, taking a deep and strained breath.

-

Catra didn't like thinking of the next part, the part that she always kept trying to push down ever since she had abandoned her too.

But minds are certainly strange, aren't they?

She remembered.

She remembered being angry, blazingly pissed when Scorpia had come back with the broken recordings with that sad fucking face. She remembered yelling, she remembered Scorpia taking it but that last part...

That part she didn't like thinking about anymore.

Her claws had worked on impulse, her teeth were bared, everything red and angry and nothing but fire and thorns.

She had fire in her veins, lava that had spurred her on with embers under her feet.

She launched herself at Scorpia.

She had ripped apart her exposed skin.

She left her on the ground.

Her words echoing afterward.

"Why did you do it? Why did you do that? I thought we were friends."

She didn't remember anymore, didn't know.

All she remembered was the note that said she'd left.

The clattering of the badge.

The regret, the anger, the sadness, one emotion after another, raging through her body with tsunami force and crashing blows. She remembered the way she'd spent the night sobbing into her pillow, into her arms, how she tore everything apart and broke and felt...

Numb.

The sandstorm finally stopped.

Or maybe it'd stopped a while ago.

She didn't know.

But now her face was wet with tears and she felt like shit for crying about it.

-

She started her journey the minute the moons were lower and the air not so hot.

It took a while to break down the tent and pack everything up. She managed, though.

She always could.

The first week of traveling, she'd only gone far enough to get maybe a bit under 20 miles away from where she started, off to the North.

Pretty good considering she was walking for 6 hours over uneven and borderline dangerous terrain.

She learned really fast that she couldn't be outside in the middle of the day or night. It'd get cold enough that the reptilian animals in the desert all went into hiding, basically freezing in the night.

The first week was also the time she ran out of rations.

She soon started to understand why Entrapta kept notes.

She, after having found an empty tin container, probably for coffee, had decided what she was going to do.

"Hope I don't regret this," she said as she started to chop up the plants around her camp for the night. She shivered in the cold and wished she'd had a blanket or something. She picked them up and

started to chop them into smaller sections. The whole time, she thought.

You had a lot of time to think when you're here, you know.

The straightened and cut up sections of branches clattered inside of the tin.

A stick pushed it into the fire, steam starting to burst from the hole she'd poked in the lid.

And she waited.

There'd been enough rations for about a week. She'd have to find food soon.

As she chewed on the ration bar, she thought back to her flings in the Horde again.

Amelia, Persephone, those were the only two that counted to her. Those were the only two that looked enough like Adora to matter.

Memories of their times together flashed through her mind. A recording she never pressed play on.

And so it began.

And so it went.

And so it started to play again.

-

Catra didn't like to kiss her flings.

It felt too intimate somehow.

So, the woman grabbed her wrist and scrambled for her back, desperately clawing at her shoulders.

She thought.

Maybe.

So she bent down and placed sloppy, haphazard ones down her neck, up her jawline, and tried to chase away something that was building in her chest like a sob.

Never to be released.

The woman moaned in her ear.

Never to be relieved.

Her body held up, leaning over her, grinding hips against hers, they frantically danced the lovers' dance.

But Catra couldn't care less.

None of this mattered.

Nothing mattered.

So when the woman, Amelia, tugged at her hair as she shivered, jerked, and finally stilled under her,

She felt nothing.

Numb.

Empty.

Temporarily sated.

But so, so empty.

-

The charcoal was ready.

She took the tin off the flames and set it off to the side.

Being in the Waste taught her boredom, taught her that she had nothing to do but stew and simmer in her own thoughts.

While she waited for the charcoal to cool, she finished her last ration bar. She leaned back, crossed her arms over her chest, and shut her eyes with a sigh, leaning against the tent wall.

She decided to make charcoal after realizing that there was nothing else to do here. She wanted to draw, to do something more than just waste her days walking through the sand and passing by plants and animals she wanted to remember were edible.

It was helpful information, right?

She woke up shivering with only ashes in place of the fire. She stood up and grabbed the cooled charcoal tin. It felt light in her aching hands and she walked into the tent.

Inside, she lay on the floor of the tent. Its shelter was much appreciated here.

The charcoal didn’t crumble in her hands and actually looked okay.

For her twelfth attempt, that is. All the others had burst into flames and she had opened it too early.

Regardless, she had charcoal and she intended to use it now.

So she did.

-

The second week, she made a terrible mistake, a risky and almost deadly one.

Her body ached, everything sore and cramping. Her head throbbed and she couldn’t do anything other than vomit for an

hour. She heard someone laughing at her, never finding the source.

She was determined to eat that plant, though. It had too much water to be wasted.

After she'd gotten done being poisoned, she sketched out the plant and gave them a name. She wanted to call them something she could remember.

Lengua Del Diablo

Yeah, that would work.

She decided she'd attempt to cook it, maybe burn out some of the toxins.

Surprisingly? It actually worked.

She'd decided to boil it in another discarded crushed can she'd found. She let it boil until it puffed up and tasted sweeter instead of having such a bitter aftertaste she would gag while waiting for it to fade away.

-

Day 19.

While she thought about everything, she really realized that maybe Scorpia was right.

Maybe she wasn't a good friend.

She sighed and ran a hand through her spiky hair, now slightly grown, and winced at the stretching in her hands.

The moons were low, making the Waste cold enough to safely explore but not cold enough to freeze just yet.

That'd come in about six more hours.

Sweat beaded on her forehead and along her body as she walked. She wanted to take a break, mostly because there was a giant canyon she'd need to get through and she really didn't want to have to brave quicksand and deadly things again right now.

Still, she pressed on.

Her breathing was starting to come out heavy and *diablos* , her legs hurt a storm.

Water.

She had made a tin of the pulpy water of the Lengua Del Diablo plant for drinking a while ago.

The canteen had run dry rather slowly, luckily.

She'd butchered the plant when she saw it the first time.

Its roots were long, spindly when young, and hard to break through. They grew out of the sides of the tall, forked stalk with forked leaves stiff with a bone-like core that jutted out from the ground like a talon. Spikes jutted from the surface of the cactus like sewing needles, which she used them exactly for.

They were useful when it came to making repairs to the tent's rips and tears. She'd made twine out of the roots and stitched with the needles.

Regardless.

Every part of the plant was useful in some way. She made sure to use it when she first cut it apart. Its water tasted almost acidic with its bitterness that slammed into her tongue after the burst of sweetness. The shell, thick and gummy when boiled, made for a good chewing gum when she wanted to chew on it.

She opened up the top of the can with a pop and chugged the pulpy water. Each gulp filled her body with chills.

Refreshing, at least.

It was a familiar taste she didn't love but at least knew well enough by now.

She wiped her mouth with the back of her hand and put the can away in her backpack. The moons were getting lower and she had to choose.

Rest now or push on and rest a bit later.

She chose now.

She was exhausted, to say the least.

The tent setup took a bit longer than it usually did. It was alright.

She walked inside and promptly collapsed onto the sleeping bag. She stood up again after a bit and zipped up the fraying and sticking zipper.

The compass stayed firmly against her chest and she was suddenly very aware of its weight. After she zipped up the tent, she took out the compass again.

The next landmark was due Northwest from where she'd shot its azimuth back several miles ago. Based on her natural sense of direction and how strong it was, she assumed she was getting closer.

Probably, maybe.

Maybe around 100 miles away by now.

She'd be fine, she could walk that in not too many days.

Everything would be fine.

Everything is under control.

-

Day 21

-

The next day’s walk was harder than the 20th day’s walk. It was an exhausting, too-hot day. Likely summer.

Something seemed wrong but she didn't know how or what.

As she walked, she noticed little bugs flying around her vision. Her hands ached in the dry air and she swatted at the bugs when they flew in her face.

No contact, though, weirdly enough.

Something was watching her.

She rubbed her aching arms, they were sore again. Her arms and legs and stomach kept aching and feeling sorer by the day. She kept walking through the valley? the canyon? there were a lot of rocky cliffs that shielded her view and made her rely more on her compass than always.

“Catra...”

She perked her ear and spun around. Her backpack uncomfortably slammed against her arm and her compass clattered against her chest. Her breathing was starting to come out a bit shallow and rougher by the hour.

“What?” she asked.

No response, nobody there.

She flicked her ear and turned back around. She ran a hand through her growing hair and sighed again.

“Just the wind. It’s just the wind,” she said. She smelled a thunderstorm coming and looked up.

Nothing there, no clouds.

Still.

She took off her backpack and settled down on the ground to set up camp again for the storm.

Besides, ahead of her was a big wall of roots that she thought came from the Lengua Del Diablo based on how the roots shivered in the wind.

-

By the time she was finished, she realized.

She hadn't eaten since she started walking at sunrise.

It was the middle of the day now.

She took out her axe and pushed aside the tent flap. After sizing up the challenger, she started chopping up the Lengua Del Diablo with the axe. It broke away with effort and fell down like a tree. With a clatter, the roots broke off and fell with the green stalks and leaves.

She picked up the stalk, hoisted it over her shoulder, and started dragging it to her campsite.

-

The fire crackled and she was filled with a sense of familiarity.

The plant was starting to puff up in the boiling water and started getting softer by the minute.

She poked it with the bone of the leaf and scooped it out with a dried vine of a bramble that grew here she'd cooked and dried herself.

She scooped it onto her plate of wood chips and dug in with her hands. It crunched under her teeth.

The flavor was akin to that of the pastries she'd stolen in the Horde.

More like coffee and chocolate, maybe nutty.

The sun was oppressive, burning her exposed skin a bit. When she finished she could almost convince herself she felt better. Less hungry, less thirsty, better.

Maybe she was convincing herself.

But she wasn't.

She absolutely wasn't.

"Catra."

"What?" she spun around again. Her ears were laid back and she showed her teeth, "Stop talking to me!"

Nobody but the tent and crackling fire.

She huffed and stood up to put the plate away. She dipped into the tent and lay down on the floor again. Her walks were getting shorter, more unsteady, and shaky.

But this was fine.

She was doing fine.

"Hello?" someone else said.

"Hi, my name is..." said another voice, someone nearby.

Catra covered her ears and shut her eyes. "Shut up," she said, drawing out the hiss of the sound.

The wind was kicking up. Dust was hitting the tent. The tent was shifting under her body and adjusting with each gust of wind.

She screamed until she ran out of breath.

Her eyes were screwed shut and she rolled onto her side, thrashing around and growling as the wind kicked up.

The tent ripped and whipped around.

She didn't know. She didn't know what was going on anymore.

Nothing was right, was it?

The wind died down.

The voices turned to whispers, stopped.

She looked over and the tent was fine, nothing was damaged.

When she looked out the flap, the fire was fine.

She kicked sand onto the fire to kill it and picked up everything to pack up.

It was exhausting. It was only a day away from the bar by now.

Only a day.

Just a day.

She felt her face wet. Was it sweat? Was it tears? She couldn't tell anymore.

"I'm sorry," she said to nobody and everybody. Scorpia, Adora, Entrapta, everyone.

This was some mind trick. Some sort of test. It was something to teach her a lesson.

She was listening.

And she was losing, failing again, wasn't she?

She shook her head and fell asleep to an aching body and the sound of thunder.

-

“Catra,” came a voice.

Adora.

“Adora?” She stood up straighter and looked at her. She stood there, too far away. “Adora!” She started to run, stumble, and move as fast as she could.

She was getting closer...something was wrong with this dream.

Roots of the Lengua Del Diablo emerged from the sandy ground, choking out Adora from her view. “Adora! Come back!” she tripped and when she looked up again, Adora was standing above her.

She looked...

Hurt.

“Adora?”

“Please, Catra. Please don’t do this...please,” she stepped back, closer to the thorns, closer to danger.

“Adora!” she stood up again and when she reached out to grab her wrist, she shoved her into the thorns instead.

Adora’s face flashed with Scorpia’s, Entrapta’s, back to Adora again.

She reached to grab the roots, pry away their tight grips from her Adora. “I got you. I’m not giving up on you! I won’t—“ she screamed and watched in horror as the roots wrapped around her wrists and pulled her away.

Away from Adora.

“Catra...please...” Adora’s body pressed harder against the thorns as roots grew hair-like thorns and turned the striped tan of her

own skin coiled around her like a tight hug. Their thorns dug into her body like clawed hands.

Catra reached again, stretching out her hand. Tears fell from her eyes and tried to stop the roots from wrapping harder, squishing and constricting her like snakes.

She looked at the roots covering herself and jerked her hand to rip them away.

-

She woke up swinging her arm through the air with a gasp.

Her breathing came out heavy and she sat up with a jolt.

"You're hurting them...them...stupid..." came a whisper.

She was too tired to care right now.

She collapsed again and shut her eyes. She fell into a dreamless sleep and woke up to the sun setting.

Perfect.

Another day of walking.

She gathered up her things and started to break down the tent. Her clothes were starting to fray and tear at the seams with holes the thickness of her thumb.

She flicked and swiveled her ear at the sound of another voice she couldn't quite discern the words of.

Someone was watching her again.

"Flesh..."

She sighed and sat up. The sound was back and she was tired of it by now.

She took out her knife from her sheath of the plant's shell and brandished it, "Who are you?"

"Flesh,"

The deep voice again. Where was—

A lizard emerged from the ground and looked at her with large, amber eyes. It smiled with human teeth, opened its mouth, and charged at her. "Flesh!"

She lunged at it and drove her knife through its back.

The illusion faded.

The lizard was screeching and thrashing in the throes of death. Blood oozed from its back as it lashed its tail. It kicked up sand and bit her hand.

Blood.

Catra hissed, ripped the knife out, and drove it into its head this time.

The crimson fluid sprayed and, as it met with air, solidified almost immediately and fell as beads of red. It gushed from the lizard's head as she took the knife roughly from it. The blood glued the knife to its head and took its body with it.

She scowled and wiped it off against the sand.

The sand clung to the solidified blood and lizard like strings of bloodied flesh.

"Get off," she grumbled. Her ear twitched.

The lizard stared at her with bloodied eyes framed by goo.

"Catra..." it said in Adora's voice, "why did you do it?"

"Shut up!" Catra screamed and flicked its body off.

It thudded against the sand in a bloodied heap.

Around her, voices screamed her name and their anguish. The blade was heating up from the sunlight.

When did she stop sweating?

She saw Adora in the distance and crumpled to her knees.

It was the dream again.

It played out in real life.

She was emerging from the roots, glaring at her against the light.

“I’m sorry...” she said. Weakness, the heat, her body hurt, everything hurt.

“I’m...” she lay flat on the sand and rock, probably cutting her face somewhere, “I love you.”

As her vision blackened, she heard a voice call her name and someone run to her side, bending down.

I’m sorry.

Chapter End Notes

> Haha wasn't that wild? Anyway, now for the part where Catra gets therapy and adopted. Found family go brrr. So, turns out that I might have BPD. I was not aware of this and have now started to project myself on this poor fucking catgirl and base it off my own growth and development and mannerisms blah blah blah. I also based the hallucinations off of my own. Really the only inaccurate one was the lizard hallucination. The most I saw was an ant spin around, smile, and laugh at me before fading into a normal ant again. Not quite as dramatic as seeing one scream "FLESH" at me, fun.
> Anyway! See you in uhhhhh six...months ig?
> I wrote this entire chapter on paper and struggled to read my

shit handwriting! It was really fun not going to lie to y'all.
I might do it again since it really helped with my productivity.
Now to write a loving mother figure...
How do you do that, anyway?

And Pain...

Chapter Summary

> So it wasn't Adora. Catra wakes up in a house she's never seen with a person she's never met showing her something she's never had.
> Why wasn't she dead yet? Why was she still alive?

Chapter Notes

> So I decided to try and make it so that I'd upload every month or so. I will likely not follow this pattern but whatever it's probably fine. Anyway, yeah so no Adora...again. She'll appear in a bit, I think? Probably. This is a heavily Catra-centered fic and I have no intention to change that. I once again handwrote this and have no intention not to do that again. It's fun, it makes me happy, I actually do things when I do it like that.
> Regardless, no Adora yet, we only have lizardfolk here and Catra.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra woke up with a jolt and a gasp.

She looked around the room she was now in. Someone was cooking something based on the faint smell of fungi and spices.

She groaned and curled in on herself, feeling the effects of being poisoned for almost three weeks kicking in at its fullest.

The door opened and she snapped her eyes open. She snarled and pressed her ears flat against her head, weak and too pathetic to count.

She was too tired, too weak right now.

Plus, she had no weapons or anything on her.

“Oh, you’re awake,” said the voice from the figure.

Catra immediately smelled scales, old age, female.

An older lizardfolk, one that smelled vaguely familiar, too, somehow.

“Sorry for bringing you here without warning but…” she chuckled and it was such a nice sound, “you weren’t conscious and about to die. I figured you’d—“

“Who are you?” Catra asked.

She smiled with yellowed teeth, all fangs in a not unfriendly way, “Elizabeth. Do you recognize me?”

Catra looked at her again with narrowed eyes and frowned.

Brown and tan scales, splotches of tan along her body and arms, brown jacket, tan shorts, a dagger sheath at her hip, amber eyes.

She pursed her lips and shut her eyes with a groan.

“I was in your gang. I was with Tung Lashor, before you came in,” she said. She was sitting in a chair now and looking over her. “You beat him so fast,” she said.

Catra found no joy in that. Having been in such a dark place at that time, the portal incident…

She shut her eyes and clutched her stomach.

“Here.”

She heard a glass placed on the bed stand, a simple cardboard box in a little wooden room, with her little wooden bed. It had a black liquid in it and she reached over to grab it. Anything was probably better than the poisonous water she’d been drinking for so long.

Plus, what did she have to lose? She was basically dead anyway so might as well hope this finishes the job.

After chugging it down, she winced at the flavor and lay down again with a sigh.

A pet on her leg and she hissed.

“I’ll be in the other room. If you need me, I’ll be there,” Elizabeth said with another kind and toothy smile.

Catra simply nodded and watched her leave.

Her heart suddenly raced, beat faster, breathing shallow and quick. She shivered and groaned and looked around frantically. “Elizabeth!” she cried out, an almost desperate sound.

As if she had never left, the door opened and she was there again. She drew the chair back and sat down. “What happened?” she asked, so simple, so soft.

Catra’s heart raced again, fear, anxiety, some semblance of anger maybe? She tried to unsheathe her claws again and attempted to scratch herself. She whimpered and hissed in agony.

“Hey, hey. It’s okay. Catra. Deep breaths,” her voice was so soothing.

Is that kindness?

She ran her hands, fingers, along her arms and shut her eyes. Body shaking, shivering, blacking out the world.

“Catra. Come here, come back.”

Catra opened her eyes. Elizabeth wasn’t looking at her, just slightly away. She was breathing slowly and deeply.

“In…”

Catra breathed in with a choking sob.

“Out…”

She breathed out in a quick burst and held herself with tight arms.

“In…”

Another shaky breath, another sob, slower, slower.

“Out…”

She curled up and sobbed.

Why was she listening to this random person she’d never known? Why did she feel so scared? What was wrong with her?

Something’s wrong, something’s wrong, something’s wrong.

“In…”

She took another breath, slower now.

“Out…”

Another breath out. She shut her eyes and held herself harder, curling up.

“What do you need right now?” Elizabeth asked.

“Please…please don’t leave,” Catra choked out.

Elizabeth was quiet. She nodded and rested on the chair, reclining slightly. “Later, I’m getting you food. I’ll be leaving for a bit. I’m not leaving you forever. I’m not abandoning you,” she said.

“You can leave if you want. I don’t care,” Catra said.

Did she, though? Did she not care?

Something fluttered in her chest when Elizabeth helped her, actually cared, actually came back, even if she didn’t know her.

“I’ll be right back. I’m getting you food but I will return,” she said.

Catra said nothing and let go of herself, curling up and stroking her tail tip. She waited as the door closed, as the smells were replaced by clicking utensils and dishes being moved. She wanted to explore this new house, this new place, but she still didn’t feel well enough to right now. Soon, though.

Soon.

She rolled onto her other side and faced the wall. She shut her eyes, took a deep breath, and let it out with a sigh.

She’d sleep.

She’d sleep and everything would be fine.

Maybe she’d die in her sleep from the poisons she ate.

Maybe, maybe, maybe.

She lost herself to sleep.

The nightmares began again.

—

There she was.

Her ray of sunshine, her beacon of hope and safety with her dumb hopeful face and her soft eyes.

Adora.

She had her arms stretched out and Catra ran over. She leaped into her arms and held her so tight that she swore that maybe she’d come back again.

The air smelled of hyacinths and flowers she only smelled in Plumeria when they were raiding it recently, sometime so long ago she'd forgotten.

She held her close and waited, what for, she didn't know yet.

"Catra…" Adora said.

"Yeah?" Catra looked over and it was Amelia, it was Persephone, it was all of her flings again.

"Why did you do it?" she asked. Her voice was soft, filled with a sort of sadness that made her blazingly pissed.

She struggled, trying to escape from her arms.

The Adora, monster, whatever, held her tight. Stony arms held her in place, sending jolts of pain in electricity through her body. It burned, everything burned so, so much.

"Stop it!" she said, a sob.

"Tell me, Catra," she said, arms turning to the thorned vines and roots of the Lengua Del Diablo, "Why? Why did you do it?"

Why? Why did she?

She struggled and sobbed and kicked and squirmed. Everything burned and hurt and ached and she couldn't breathe.

"I'm sorry!" she said.

I wanted to die.

—

She lay there, breathing heavily.

“I wanted to die,” she said aloud.

Elizabeth came into the room holding a bowl of soup and a glass of water.

—

There was some hint of sadness in the air as she started to get better and stronger by the days. Every muscle in her body hurt, though. She rested on the chair, eyeing the surroundings in the room and the way the room was so slightly furnished. No photos, no major windows except for one small one covered by a handmade curtain, and a handmade rug with her bed and a solar-powered lamp beside it on a cardboard box.

She lay there, not sure what to do now that she was feeling a bit better. She’d been bedridden for nearly a week, maybe. Time was hard to tell inside of the room.

The window let in light that she relished in, enjoying the subtle warmth it brought.

Everything was almost alright now.

The door opened and she jumped.

“Oh, sorry,” Elizabeth said as she walked into the room with a bowl of some stir fry.

“No big deal, it’s fine,” she said.

“How are you feeling?”

Catra shut her eyes, took a breath, and looked inwards. She felt herself in a way she’d learned over the years. “I’m hungry,” she said at last.

Elizabeth smiled and set the bowl down on the cardboard box, "Good news, I have food."

"Thank you," she reached for it and held the wooden spoon and fork, and started to eat slowly. Every bite she savored, enjoying its flavor.

It was nice.

"How is it?"

"Delicious."

Elizabeth smiled and sat cross legged on the floor next to her and ate her own bowl of stir fry. "You seem bored, mija," she said.

Mija?

"Do you…"

"No es importante. I'll get you books to read. Stay here," she said. She set her bowl aside and stood up with a sigh.

Catra started to learn, so slowly, that Elizabeth would be back. She'd be back. It was okay.

The door opened and Catra got a quick peek outside.

The rest of the house looked so…comfortable.

She made it her next goal to explore the house after she started to feel better.

Probably tomorrow at this point.

She finished the food right when Elizabeth came back with a small stack of books.

"How was it?" she asked. She set the books down on the cardboard box.

Catra held the bowl out to her and she took it from her, “It was delicious.”

“I’m glad to hear. Would you like to know what I put in it?” she asked.

Catra nodded.

Elizabeth held out her bowl to her. She pointed to the meat-looking chunk of food, “That is scorpion meat.” She pointed to the vegetables, “I think you’ll recognize this one. This one is the tubers of the cacti here, plus several innards of the trees that grow here,” she smiled and sat back.

“It was delicious. Did you use any of the birds I’ve seen around here?” Catra asked.

“Of course, mija,” she said.

Catra found herself reveling in the warmth of hearing herself be called mija.

Mija…

She picked up a book at random and looked over it.

“I’ll leave you to read now,” she patted her knee with a peeling and shedding hand, “I’ll be in the other room.” She stood up and left the room with both bowls in her hands. She opened the door with a foot and left just as easily.

Catra watched her go. Her eyes lingered on the door before she turned back to the book again. It was something about helping others with problems based on the synopsis.

She flipped lazily through the pages and turned to one of them.

It spoke of talking through problems, through your struggles, with others. It mentioned how you should find someone to confide in

and trust and how you need support during hard times. It talked about how that was okay.

She thought of Adora and shut her eyes. The thought of her with her hopeful and weird face tunneled its way into her head like the worms and lizards that lived here.

It annoyed her.

She turned to a different page and skimmed over it. It felt nice, felt good, to read something that wasn't propaganda and false information.

Well, fake as much as she knew at least.

The book was actually kind of interesting to her. It kind of made her want to read again.

She set it aside and grabbed a different book. A simple fiction one.

It was nice to read something that didn't remind her of her old friend.

Her old friend, her old love.

She turned to the synopsis and started to read through it.

Science fiction.

Nice.

She opened it up to the first page and started to read for the first time in almost two months.

—

The next day, she entered the rest of the house.

With gentle and light steps, she walked into the living room. It was still early in the morning and she needed to find where the books were stored.

Her eyes scanned the house, the wooden floors, the wooden walls with rugs that were handmade like her own comforter and rug. She held the book in her aching hands and snuck around.

The kitchen reminded her of her idea of an actual home. It had the smallest of stoves, a fridge that buzzed loudly, and the cabinets above a black countertop. She didn't know what kind of material any of it was made of though.

She snuck around and winced as the floorboards creaked underfoot in the surprisingly empty and large house. It was comfortable, pleasant, warm. The light came in through a window over the sink and to the side of the cabinets. Dust could be seen floating lazily through the air.

It was…

Nice.

There.

She saw an absolutely massive bookshelf that took up almost half of the wall furthest from another door she assumed was the master bedroom based on the creaking inside.

She eyed the bookshelves that lined the wall, eyeing the door to the bedroom off to the right of it.

Alphabetical order.

Okay.

She turned the book over and put it in the space next to the other G authors in the bookshelf.

Catra glanced over at Elizabeth's room. It was right next to her own room with only a wall to separate them. Thick enough that she couldn't easily hear her, but thin enough to stop heat from coming in and staying from outside. She wondered just what it looked like inside.

She turned her attention back to the bookshelves and went over the other books on the shelf.

Something with acronyms caught her attention.

Plus the word "Therapy" which was something she hadn't heard of for quite some time.

She looked around and took it off the shelf. She stuck it under her arm and walked off at a fast pace back towards her room. When she reached the door, though, she glanced over at the others.

She took her hand off the doorknob and walked around to explore the house more.

She opened a folding door.

Laundry room. It had a white washing machine and a dryer in it.

She shut the doors.

There was another wall to the side of the room and she walked around it.

Oh. An actual bathroom.

She turned on the lights and shut the door behind her. Considering it had been a little over a week since she'd used something other than a bucket to shit in, this seemed like luxury.

The room was dark grey with black tile floors. There was a bathtub and shower at the furthest wall plus the toilet and sink right next to it.

That’d be useful.

She walked to the sink and started to wash her hands.

It was weird to have actual water here considering it was the Waste and there was no water in sight.

The water smelled familiar.

She leaned down and smelled it.

Plant-like, almost bitter.

Oh, that’s what it was.

She shut off the water.

“She’s using Lengua Del Diablo water to wash with?” she asked in a mutter. She flicked her hands dry and looked at her reflection for the first time in months.

Her hair had grown out a bit since being shaved when she was exiled. Her face had some new wrinkles and she looked harder and had an almost empty look in her eyes.

She was reminded of her time in the Horde and scowled.

She leaned down and washed her face in the water she turned on again. She leaned back up and dried her face and hands with a towel hanging from a handle on the wall.

It was a bit scratchy which was almost nice.

It reminded her that she was alive, somehow.

Her hair had grown to be fairly long, about an inch or so at most. It didn’t get in the way yet but was still much too short for her liking.

She picked up the book, opened the door, and shut off the lights. She started her path back to her room again with her contraband.

The house seemed like it was starting to wake up now.

Her room gave her a sense of familiarity now. The handwoven comforter and rug were a pleasant splash of color in a room covered in browns.

The bed creaked under her weight as she sat on it and looked through her newly acquired book. It was a deep blue and had white lettering.

Its pages were stiff and slightly yellowed.

She flipped to one page and saw scrawled notes.

Her cheeks almost flushed as she tried to avoid reading them. They must've been Elizabeth's notes.

She opened the book again and started to read it, including the notes.

It had actual lines, actual places to write in. It looked…

Like a worksheet, an assignment.

She looked through Elizabeth's work and found herself…

Relating to what she wrote.

The things in the book said such helpful things. Hard, difficult things that she wasn't sure if she could do, but wow, these examples and Elizabeth's work here were…familiar.

One went over the abandonment issues and her heart stopped for a second. She held her breath and read over it. Something about how people won't abandon you, how you should remind yourself of that.

She clutched the paper hard and sighed.

How do I do that? How do I forget what she did to me?

A knock on the door startled her and she nearly threw the book under the blanket. “What?”

The door opened and Elizabeth walked in. She immediately saw the book peeking out from under the blanket based on the subtle glance at it. She looked back at her again, “I heard you shuffling around. Are you okay?”

“I’m fine,” she said. She was still stiff and unsettled.

Elizabeth looked at her, narrowed her eyes, and leaned against the doorway, “What were you reading?”

“Nothing!”

Elizabeth stood there in silence.

Catra shut her eyes, sighed, and took the book out again. She held it out to her. Strong hands took it from hers and she watched as she looked over the book.

“I remember doing the work in this before,” she said.

Catra’s ears perked ever-so-slightly before she flattened them again in her neutral show of annoyance and anger.

“You read my notes?”

Catra nodded.

Elizabeth handed it to her again. “Keep reading it and do the work. I’ll give you some paper to do the work on when I go shopping later,” she said. She pushed herself off the wall and walked out with a gentle shut of the door.

Catra held the heavy book in her hands and looked over it. She brushed the pad of her finger over the surface. She wanted to read more.

So she did.

—

After having read it for nearly 3 hours, Catra found herself dozing off with the moon at its highest. It reminded her of how Elizabeth's activity in the house would lessen around this time.

She also noticed herself feeling some sense of solidarity with Elizabeth now that she'd read this.

It all reminded her of what she'd done, things she'd said and had thought too.

She thought back to all of her flings. All of her Adora replacements filled her mind.

She stood up and, armed with this new knowledge, walked out of her room and towards Elizabeth's. She knocked on the door until she heard shuffling steps and muttering. The door opened.

"Can I come with you to shop?" Catra asked.

Elizabeth looked over at the wall, a ticking clock filling it, and squinted, "Sure. We can go together. Give me another hour, mija," she said in a tired and soft voice.

Catra nodded and waited for her to shut the door before she walked back to her room again. The floor was cold despite the heat from outside.

She sat down on the wooden chair and crossed her legs. She opened the book again and started to go over the older pages and ones that seemed less stuck in her mind still. It was hard to take in but she knew that she couldn't take a nap now.

So she read.

And read.

And read.

—

“Catra,” came a voice.

She jolted awake and blinked away the light.

Elizabeth was armed with her usual weaponry and was standing at the doorway. “Are you ready?”

Catra looked over herself in her ragged, dirty clothes still breezy and uncomfortable, and shrugged.

“Good enough. Let’s go,” Elizabeth jerked her head and walked out. She left the door open behind her.

Catra walked over and straightened out her clothes. She made sure the book was securely and safely on the chair before she closed the door. Her clothes were starting to bug her so she decided she’d buy another outfit when she could.

Or steal one.

Whichever.

The moon was starting to go down a bit and she found herself being reminded of times in the Waste trying to survive. She’d been poisoning herself, dying so, so slowly. It had destabilized her so hard and so badly.

She walked after Elizabeth onto the hot sands she’d learned to tolerate by now.

“You left for the Horde again, didn’t you?” Elizabeth asked as she walked across the sand.

“Yeah.”

“Why are you back here?” She pointed ahead, “Shopping center is an 8-minute walk from here.”

“Thanks. I was exiled for…reasons,” she said. She held her arm and kept walking as the moon was starting to very slowly reach the side closer to setting now.

Elizabeth hummed and kept on in silence.

“What’s in the shopping center?”

“A bit of this, that, anything you need,” she said.

Catra thought for a minute. “Anything?” she asked.

Elizabeth eyed her, “What are you thinking of?”

She didn’t know. Didn’t know what she was even thinking of.

Mostly she was thinking of the whip again, the one she’d gotten and had proceeded to lose during her exile. She shrugged, “Maybe a whip, maybe a dagger again.”

Elizabeth kept silent and continued to walk on.

Ahead, the shopping center could be seen.

Or at least what could be considered one.

It was mostly a collection of covered stalls and buildings with shady-looking figures running them. There was someone with an eyepatch, another with a missing arm, another with a missing leg and a partly scaly and partly furry body.

Hybrids, outcasts, criminals, it made sense.

Catra straightened her back, instinctively trying to flex and unsheathe her claws, finding herself disappointed again when they weren't there once more.

"For fucks sake," she grumbled. She held her hands in fists and walked on.

"We'll get you something for that," Elizabeth said. She patted her on the shoulder and Catra stiffened up.

Elizabeth let go and muttered an apology.

Catra forgave her. She hadn't known her yet.

Not yet.

Their first stop was at the clothing store, or at least what looked like one.

Another lizardfolk was running the place. She was missing an arm and had peeling scales. She was also wearing the familiar necklace of one of the lesser gangs of the Waste. It had a small, burnt-on symbol of a snake skull with an arrow through it on a wooden pendant.

Catra looked over the clothing, anything she liked or at least could manage to not hate herself in if she wore.

"That one?" Elizabeth asked when Catra lingered by some for a bit too long.

She nodded.

"Fiber from the Devil's Whip, genuine snakeskin," the shopkeeper said in a smooth voice. "Cost you a lot."

Catra didn't bother listening too much as Elizabeth bartered with her. She was leaning against the counter, waving a hand and smiling a toothy smile as always.

“Can’t you give a discount for an old and senior customer?” Elizabeth asked. “After all, I’ve been here longer than you’ve been alive. Why not give an old lady a discount?”

“You’re buying it for the kid there. No. Pay the price.”

“She’s an outsider. I’m her guide here. Come on. Just a little discount? I’ll even throw in a cup of genuine Devil’s Whip seeds.”

The shopkeeper narrowed her eyes, “Make it two.”

“One and a half.”

“Two.”

Catra desperately wanted to claw the shopkeeper’s face, show her who she was messing with.

Fuck you, I could steal from this store if I wanted to.

“Deal.”

Catra snapped back to attention again.

Elizabeth handed her the clothes and smiled, “Don’t worry, nothing to worry about.” She leaned forward, “One cup of Devil’s Whip seeds, a cup of the syrup, and forty coins.”

Catra frowned, “Is that a lot?”

Elizabeth chuckled, “No, mija, it isn’t.”

Catra walked out of the store with her new clothes in her hands and felt the material.

Scratchy, slightly soft somehow, rough and bumpy in the snakeskin sections.

Looked comfortable.

“Do you still have your jacket?” Elizabeth asked.

“No. I lost it in the Horde,” Catra said.

She nodded and pulled out her dagger. “Stay. I’ll be back.”

Catra stood there in the streets. eyeing the people walking by. She glared at them as they walked past and kept her ears swiveling at attention. She snarled at those that looked at her for a bit too long and clutched her clothes with a hard grip.

Elizabeth came back with a jacket with the familiar insignia of the gang.

“That was fast,” Catra remarked.

Elizabeth jerked her head at the stands, “Let’s keep going.”

That wasn’t an explanation but okay.

They walked to their house with each other’s company, Elizabeth explaining the workings of the place, the system, her dues.

“Memory’s good,” Elizabeth said as they walked back to the house. She was about 300 coins poorer, luckily not bad considering the average cost for a new shirt in the Horde was double that.

“What do you owe everyone?” Catra asked. She had a new dagger on a belt along with a whip and a canteen on her hip.

Elizabeth was holding the stack of papers she’d promised to buy for her, “100 to the shopkeeper for the whip, 40 and a cup of syrup and one and a half of the Devil’s Whip seeds for—“

“What’s the Devil’s Whip?”

Elizabeth smiled, “The plant you were eating and poisoning yourself with.”

“The Lengua Del Diablo?” Catra asked.

“Is that what you called it?” Elizabeth made a “huh” noise and smiled. “I loved the drawings of your surroundings. Very well done

considering your health," she said.

"So you call it the Devil's Whip?"

"Sí. It looks like one, doesn't it?"

"I'd say it does, yeah."

They continued to talk as they walked home. When they got home, Catra promptly collapsed on the living room couch and sighed.

"Do you want to go to the Valley tomorrow?" Elizabeth asked. She was standing in the kitchen and taking off her dagger and other weapons and setting them on the counter and table.

"The Valley?"

"The Valley of the Lost. Many criminals and others in the Waste live there, make a good life there," she said. She sighed and stretched her arms until her elbows popped.

Catra shrugged. "Okay, tomorrow, though."

"Tomorrow."

—

Tomorrow would prove to be a strange day.

Catra chatted with Elizabeth as they walked into the Valley.

"So you dealt with someone abandoning you too?" she asked.

"Sí. She was my first partner and we had known one another for four years. She left me suddenly and without warning. I ended up

spiraling so hard I left the gang because I'd killed a person," she said.

Catra winced.

Too familiar.

Catra adjusted her dagger and her whip on her hip and eyed the people around her.

They broke off, Catra exploring more of the Valley casually while Elizabeth walked through the stalls, herself.

A smell.

Oh. She knew that smell.

She knew it too well.

The Horde.

She eyed the Valley.

There.

She saw someone, a soldier, wearing their armor and the Horde insignia on its back.

She wanted to know.

Could she go back? After all she'd done?

She cleared her mind, took a breath, and walked up to the soldier.

They spun around when she tapped a nearby bucket with her foot to get their attention.

Her blood ran cold.

Blue eyes.

It—

“Amelia?” Catra said.

She eyed her with those hard blue eyes and her scarred forehead and lip. “Catra. You shouldn’t be alive. You shouldn’t be here.”

“Amelia?”

Amelia looked around and gestured for her to follow her.

Catra, against her better judgment, did just that.

They stood in a shaded cubby at the Valley’s walls. Catra eyed her back, the insignia glaring at her.

She clenched her fists.

Amelia took off her helmet.

“Amelia, I’m—“

Amelia nearly lunged forward, grabbed her face by the cheeks, and planted a hard kiss against her lips.

Catra tensed up and felt herself fall into familiar, old habits.

Amelia shoved her deeper into the shadows.

Catra glanced outside of the cubby to make sure they were alone. When she looked back, they crashed their lips together again.

Amelia shoved a knee between her legs.

She whined in her ear and clutched her back with desperate hands. Catra nipped along her jaw, finding herself falling deeper and deeper again.

It burnt again.

It hurt so bad.

It felt wrong, it felt so good.

Amelia moved her knee, making Catra whimper again. She pawed at her body, nipping at her neck and pawing at her chest and her sides.

Catra hissed and clutched her hair as Amelia started making a path down her body now.

She pushed her shirt up, tracing hands down her sides. Her tongue lapped along her stomach, hands massaging her sides and hips. She clutched hard and Catra rocked against her chest and face.

Amelia's gloved hands were a strange texture against her bare skin. It didn't feel bad, it didn't feel good.

It felt.

And she felt.

She hissed and gasped.

Contact.

Catra shut her eyes and rocked her hips against Amelia's face and tongue. Her knees buckled and she clutched her hair again with a hard grip. Her fingers knotted and clutched at her ponytail.

Wrong. This was wrong. Bad. Old habits that should be broken.

Get rid of them. Stop it. This is wrong, backward progress. Falling behind.

She didn't care.

She covered her mouth to muffle a moan as Amelia's tongue went to work.

She sucked on her, lapping at her in a way that made Catra shut her eyes and whine behind her palm.

Thoughts left her mind, body focused, brain empty.

No thoughts.

No feelings.

Just now.

She felt the pressure build in her hips. She bucked and rocked against Amelia's face, fucking it relentlessly. Every movement was more and more contact, every movement more and more.

She whined and pressed her face into her deeper.

Amelia looked up at her, smiled, and growled out, "Come for me, Kitten."

Catra broke.

She let go of Amelia's hair, covered her mouth with both hands, and moaned into her palms. She bucked her hips against Amelia's face. Her body worked on impulse, writhing and squirming and moving.

Building, building.

She shut her eyes and let out a heavy sigh.

Release.

Catra slumped against the wall as Amelia wiped her mouth with the back of her gloved hand. She couldn't quite see clearly and watched as Amelia put her helmet back on.

Before she could walk off, Catra grabbed her by the shoulders and spun her around to face her. "Amelia."

"What?"

"Why did you do that?"

“I wanted to fuck you.”

Catra could tell that wasn’t it. She glared at her. “Tell me the truth, you bitch.”

Amelia shrugged her hand off roughly and shoved her away. “Fuck you,” she said with a grit of her teeth.

Catra glared at her and hissed, “Fine.”

“Meet me here. Tomorrow night.”

“Fine,” Catra said. They parted and Catra pulled her pants back up. She watched as Amelia walked off.

Catra started her walk back to the designated meeting spot.

Elizabeth was waiting there. Her face lit up when she saw her. “There you are. I’ve been waiting,” she said.

“Sorry, got caught up in something,” Catra said.

It wasn’t technically a lie.

“Here. I got these made for you the other day,” she said. She held out a pair of gloves that clicked when she moved them and Catra grabbed them from her.

Oh.

They were made of steel fibers, almost chainmail. They had adjustable leather straps along the wrists and, on the fingertips, were long and hooked talons much like her old ones.

She tried them on and, after adjusting them to fit, started to tear up. “I…” she took a shaky breath.

“I know you miss your claws. I had them made for you,” Elizabeth said. She smiled and held her hands. “Do you like them?”

Catra looked up at her with blurred vision and lunged forward. She wrapped her in a tight hug. “Thank you. Thank you so much. I love them,” she said with a shaky breath.

Meet me here tomorrow night.

Meet me here tomorrow night.

Amelia’s glaring eyes. Her scarred lip and hard jaw all chiseled corners and hard edges.

Amelia.

Old habits.

Bad habits.

Day after tomorrow.

She hugged Elizabeth harder and started to sob.

Amelia…

What happened to you?

Chapter End Notes

> So there we have it, folks. We have a weird Amelia experience and a lot of weird things going on. Anyway, I know I said Amelia wouldn't show up again but here she is. I needed to give my side characters actual plotlines so now she and Persephone are going to show up a couple more times or so before they vanish again without a trace. Also, DBT is good and I am neutral towards it and have been working on trying to read my folder with it so that I can get Catra therapy lmao. She and Elizabeth aren't as different as they thought except that Elizabeth is a seasoned lesbian.
> See y'all in a billion years again I guess? I'll be back...I will be back...

I Wonder...

Chapter Summary

> Catra has made some mistakes. She's making mistakes as she sees Amelia again. Is it really a mistake, though, when she finally finds out what happened to her and got information on Bright Moon? After learning more about the events going on in Bright Moon from the Horde's perspective she has to decide.
> Is she really ready to go to Bright Moon and join the Rebellion at last?
> With aching hands, new wrinkles on a hardened face, Catra decides.

Chapter Notes

> Ayo! It's been a little since I last posted a chapter. As the works say, this will be the second to last chapter. I really enjoyed writing this and I hope you like this chapter! I'll probably post the last chapter maybe tomorrow or some other day since I'm going to be busy tomorrow. Regardless, I have the last chapter finished and am excited for you to finally finish this! Have fun reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She would continue to read the book, do the work as Elizabeth had told her to do. Under the categories, under the lines, on the margins of the papers, she worked.

She worked.

And worked.

A knock on the door startled her again. She jumped and eyed it, “Come in.”

Elizabeth came in, peeking from the doorway, “Hey. Did you want anything? I know it’s been a couple of hours since you last ate. I wanted to make sure you’re eating enough.”

“I’m alright, Elizabeth,” Catra said.

She glanced at Catra’s papers and her scrawled writing. She looked back up, “Doing your work?”

“Yeah.”

“Alright…”

The door shut and Catra felt hollow, alone, again.

She pushed it down and away and kept doing the work.

The thought of doing random meditation, mindfulness as they called it, seemed weird. You just sit there?

She read through it again and decided she’d try it, even if it didn’t help.

Book set aside, she crossed her legs and shut her eyes.

Elizabeth’s help on her first day came to mind. She took a deep breath in, then out.

Her thoughts wandered almost immediately. She took another breath, trying to quiet her racing mind.

Adora.

She gritted her teeth as memories came back to her. Memories of Adora laughing, memories of them as children.

Memories.

She even remembered when Adora had touched her. She remembered making such an embarrassing noise. She remembered Adora’s concerned face, her curiosity. The way they

exchanged soft glances, how Catra refused to let her touch her after that.

It sounded like pain, and pain was vulnerability, and vulnerability was weakness.

Oh, right.

She shut her eyes harder and took another breath. Thoughts came around, she tried to imagine them as leaves going down a stream.

She had to watch the leaves go by. All of them. All of the thoughts of Adora, the thoughts of the Horde, the thoughts of abandonment.

What she'd done to Scorpia.

Thank the moons she hadn't killed her at least. She hadn't moved much but she'd seen her one last time before she left the Horde.

She let go of her breath and finally opened her eyes.

Too tiring.

It brought on too many memories. It all hurt to think about, it hurt so much. She shut her eyes again and sighed. She stood up and walked to the bed. Her mind ran with thoughts over and over as she lay on her bed.

It felt weird to be…loved.

Amelia.

She gritted her teeth again and stood up to look out the window. It was still daytime, still light out.

She looked at the door and got up.

Amelia.

This was a bad idea.

As she opened the door, she saw Elizabeth sitting on the living room couch reading a book. “Hello,” she said, not looking up.

“Hey. I’m going to visit a friend at the Valley again,” she said.

“A friend?”

“Yeah,” she found herself almost sweating at the thought of seeing Amelia again knowing exactly what was going to happen.

Elizabeth looked at her. She fixed her with a hard stare. With her yellow eyes staring through her, searching her and reading her like a book. “Catra,” she said.

“Yeah?”

“Be careful.”

Catra looked at her, nodded, and walked back to her room to get her weapons to protect herself with. Her clawed gloves were her favorite of them all but she did love the whip too.

The door clicked easily behind her and she looked up at the sky. The moons were high and looked nowhere near setting for now.

She couldn’t remember if she’d said to meet her at night or day.

She decided to go for day.

So along she went. She started her path to the Valley again. It wasn’t too far from the shopping center, maybe a half-hour’s walk. It wasn’t bad.

Not compared to what she’d walked before, that’s for sure.

So there she went, there she walked, how fun.

It took a little under an hour based on the path of the brightest moon as she finally got to the Valley.

There the Horde was, again.

She looked over the crowd as if to find her just from here, from this distance.

She climbed down the walls and onto the Valley floor. It didn't hurt her feet that much to land so roughly.

Someone looked at her, did a double-take, and called out.

"Catra?"

She froze.

That wasn't Amelia.

She glanced over her shoulder at the person behind her.

More blue eyes, again.

"Hey."

"You're alive?" the soldier in front of her said.

She kept track of where they were as she talked to each one. "I am, yeah. What business do you have here?"

"That information doesn't concern you," one snapped.

Funny, just a month ago she was the strongest, one of the most powerful, figures in the Horde.

Her hands stretched uncomfortably, the brands hidden under her gloves. "You should show me a bit more respect than that," she said, voice level.

Where was Amelia?

Or Persephone for that matter?

She didn’t want to look at this other figure that had blue eyes. She didn’t matter to her.

She’d kill her without a second thought if she decided to.

“Why? Because you were our superior?”

“Yeah, exactly.”

“You aren’t anymore, Kitty. So leave or we’ll make you,” the other one said, Blue Eyes or whatever.

Kitty.

She flexed her clawed gloves and glared at her, “Watch your tongue.”

Before either could talk, then, her voice.

“What’s going on here?” Amelia asked.

“Kitty Cat’s back. She’s acting all high and mighty, too,” they said.

Catra hissed and Amelia glared at her behind her helmet.

“I’ll deal with her, don’t worry.”

They looked at her with confusion or something along it and finally left them alone.

Amelia looked back at her with another glare, “What are you doing here?”

“You wanted to see me,” Catra said. She looked over her with a smirk, “Here I am.”

Amelia looked around and started to make her way off to some corner.

Catra followed.

Whirring. The smell of electricity.

Oh, fuck—

Her body convulsed, tensed up, and her vision blackened as Amelia tased her.

—

She woke up sometime later in what looked like a makeshift cell in the Valley. It was far away from the others. Amelia was standing there and watching her.

She threw herself against the bars, "What are you doing?"

"You're an enemy. You were bugging us. I had to lock you up. Now," she took out a keychain and unlocked the cell, "let's go."

Catra followed her to their spot behind the cell.

Clever.

She unhooked her gloves, which led to Amelia holding them on her wrists.

"Keep them on," she said. A command.

Catra looked into her eyes and didn't break eye contact as she started to tighten them back onto her hands again in silence. "Amelia. I won't do anything until you tell me," she said.

"Tell you what?"

"What happened to you back in the Horde."

Amelia hesitated for a fraction of a second, "I don't know what you're talking about."

Catra pressed her against the wall. She pressed her chest against hers and dug a taloned hand into the wall next to her head, "Tell me."

Amelia made a strained whimper and Catra eyed her. “Why do you want to know so bad, huh? Got close to me? Got attached or something?”

Catra dragged her claws down hard enough to leave a path in the rock, staring into her eyes. She used her other hand to trace along her jaw with a hooked claw, “No. I just wanted to know why you’re suddenly so into things like this,” she dug her claw in deep enough to leave a mark, “and to fuck me when I was all chained up in my cell and helpless to you.”

Amelia groaned and grabbed her shoulders. “You don’t know anything about me.”

“Who hurt you?”

“None of your damn business, Kitty,” she nearly spat.

Catra grabbed her shoulder and dug her claws in, squeezing it hard. She took her other hand out of the wall and held her jaw again roughly. “It was my business when you took advantage of me in that jail cell.” She rocked her chest against hers and dug her claws into her jaw, drawing blood.

Amelia gasped and actually moaned.

“Who hurt you?” she asked again.

Amelia wasn’t responding. All she was doing was standing there, a shaking and quivering mess. She dug her fingers into Catra’s shoulders and back, running them down.

Catra hissed and ran her claws down her shoulders to her chest, tiny beads of blood following it.

Amelia had her eyes screwed shut and looked somewhere between excited and on the verge of tears.

“You having fun?” Catra asked.

Amelia rocked against her and had her face buried in the crook of her neck again. She was shaking.

Catra couldn't tell if she was crying or not.

She started to take off her armor and Catra simply sat back and watched her. "Amelia," she said sternly.

Amelia stayed quiet and kept taking off her armor.

She was shaking.

"Amelia, stop," Catra grabbed her by the wrists and everything was starting to clear up again in a flash.

She struggled against her grip, now actually crying. "Just get it over with," she said, quiet and shaky.

Catra didn't know, didn't know what to do here. "Amelia. I'm not doing anything. Just tell me," she looked into her eyes, "what happened?"

"She assaulted me, okay?" she said, a shout. She teared up and Catra immediately let go.

"Who?"

"You wouldn't know her. She didn't matter," she said. She was sitting down and holding herself at the shoulders.

Catra saw herself in her and froze. She sat down with her and scooted a bit away from her to give her space.

Amelia scooted towards her.

It was weird seeing this Adora lookalike confiding in her, Catra. This wasn't normal, nobody trusted her enough to tell her anything. She was Catra.

That's all she'd ever be. A mistake, a liar, and someone never to get close to.

“I’m sorry,” she said instead.

“For what? Not listening? Not caring? Not doing anything to get her exiled or killed or whatever fucking else she deserves?” Amelia’s breaths were coming out faster.

Catra held her arms out and she scooted into them.

That was mildly unexpected if she was being honest.

She ran a hand gently down her back and tried to think of how to consul her.

“Deep breaths,” she said softly, trying to copy what Elizabeth had done for her.

Amelia’s breaths came out shaky and uneven, though she seemed to be doing her best.

“There you go. You got it…”

Amelia kept crying. She sniffled and, without looking at her, asked, “Could you do something to punish her? Anything?”

Catra thought for a moment, “I’m not part of the Horde anymore but…if I see her on a raid or out and about, I can make her hurt.”

“You promise?”

Catra stiffened up. Her mind rushed over her with the image of a young Adora holding her and saying those exact words. She remembered how scared she was, how upset, how much those words meant to her.

Crashing waves threw her mind around and about, drowning and choking her.

She relaxed again and sighed, “I’ll try.”

“Thank you.”

—

The two of them hadn’t interacted since that day for about a week before she saw her again on a shopping trip.

“Amelia?”

“Catra. You…you’re back?” she asked. She looked around, gestured for her to follow her, and led her to their spot. She sat down and, in a whisper, reported what was happening. “So, she’s going to be here soon. She’s the one with the dinged-up armor and the brown eyes. Brown, long and curly hair, hard to miss,” she said.

Catra nodded. She held the dagger in her hand. “On it. And Amelia?” she asked.

“Yeah?”

“We can’t see each other anymore after this. Can you tell me everything you know about the Rebellion when you can?”

Amelia frowned, “I haven’t been stationed outside of the Waste in weeks. I do know someone who probably does know more, though. Persephone.”

Persephone.

Catra’s breath hitched and Amelia looked over her.

“You know her. She looks like—“

“I know her. If you can somehow get her here or tell me what she knows I’d really appreciate that,” she said. She held the dagger and smiled, “I have a bitch to kill now.”

Amelia nodded, patted her shoulder, and they parted again.

Catra perched nearby in the shadows, watching the crowd of Horde soldiers.

She was starting to learn the Waste slowly, or at least the Valley.

There.

She tightened her fingers around the dagger and watched as the soldier with the dinged-up armor walked by.

Alone, no other people with her except for someone she seemed to be interrogating.

So, with a quick jump, she was behind her.

The person, a half-scaled and half-furred person she'd seen at the market, simply watched as Catra dragged her to an alley with a smooth movement. She put the dagger to the struggling woman's throat and slashed through the thinner armor on her neck with ease.

She let go and waited for her to die. Her eyes went blank, her hands to her throat, and her body convulsing, she finally lay still with glazed-over eyes.

She looked around and dragged her bloodied corpse deeper into the alley and left her there sitting upright.

"No hard feelings, ma'am. I'm not sorry, though," she said to her before standing up and starting to strip from her bloodied clothes. She wiped off the blood on her dagger on her old clothes.

When she was done and walked out of the alley, the hybrid person was gone. She looked for them for a moment, shrugged, and walked off.

They didn't matter, anyway.

She didn't really mind doing it, didn't mind killing much. Not really since being in the Horde and having to witness it and execute others on her own. She had to. She had to be okay with it or else she was weak.

And weakness was never accepted in the Horde.

When she got back to the spot, Amelia wasn't there yet. She sat down and looked over her dagger, checking it for any nicks that would need to be fixed and sharpened.

A little bit here and there, nothing she couldn't do herself though.

Footsteps, slow and heavy, nearby.

Amelia.

She looked up and Amelia looked…relieved, "Is it done?"

Catra nodded.

Amelia looked around and looked behind her. She waved a hand and Persephone walked into the spot too.

Amelia nodded and, with a hug, whispered, "Thank you," into her ear.

Catra felt a bag placed into her lap and looked down.

A bag of money.

When she looked back up, Amelia was gone.

Persephone looked back at her and sighed, "Alright. Hey, Catra," she looked at her and started to take off her helmet.

Catra wasn't expecting…

Persephone ran her hand through her short-cut hair, "You needed me?"

Catra didn't know how to talk for a bit. It made her think and imagine Adora with a similar haircut.

"Catra?"

Shit.

“Yeah, sorry. I heard you have information on Bright Moon. Can you tell me what you know?”

Persephone nodded, “Bright Moon is being weirdly quiet lately. There’s a lot of turmoil there and the Princesses haven’t been fighting as well as they usually do. I don’t know what’s going on but something is happening. Also? Scorpia is there now, too.”

“Scorpia is in Bright Moon?” Catra asked. Her blood ran cold and she thought of how she’d hurt her. “Scorpia…”

“That’s all I know. I’m sorry,” she said.

“Thank you. Even if it wasn’t much, it’s way more than what I knew before,” Catra said.

Persephone nodded and held out a wrapped item in a cloth to her. “Here. I think you could use this, too,” she said.

Catra held the cloth.

Heavy.

She recognized this shape.

“Thank you,” she said. She held the taser close to her body in her lap again and looked up at her, “How can I repay you?”

Persephone smiled, “Don’t try and come back to the Horde, okay? Don’t come back and I won’t have to report or kill you.”

Catra nodded and Persephone hugged her. She tensed up and Persephone finally let go. She cupped her cheek and looked into her eyes. Catra nodded and they kissed tenderly, fondly.

Catra held her gently, carefully, as if she’d break under her gloved hands. She wanted to be gentle with her one last time.

Especially after what happened last time.

She wanted to be gentle with her one last time.

One last time.

“Thank you,” Persephone said after she broke off the kiss.

Catra nodded and Persephone stood up and left at last, leaving her there in the dark.

—

She stayed there for some time. She didn’t feel as if she deserved to be seen right now in the light, didn’t deserve to be in the warm rays.

So there she sat, holding the pouch of money and the cloth holding the taser.

After some time, she chose to stand back up and leave the cubby.

With a puffed chest and squared shoulders, she walked.

And she walked home at last.

When she walked into the house, Elizabeth was asleep on the couch. Or at least she was. As soon as Catra walked in, she woke up with a jolt and held her dagger out.

“Who’s there?” she saw Catra and visibly relaxed, “Oh. Welcome home, Mija.”

Home.

Beautiful.

Catra put the bag of money on the kitchen table and set the taser there too. “My friends gave me these,” she said. She unhooked and undid her clawed gloves and set them on the table too.

Her hands.

She looked at them now, really looked at them in the light.

The Horde insignia stuck out of her hand pads with the same amount of aggression and anger she felt towards them.

She ran a finger over them and smiled.

They were really healed over by now. They were still there, sure, still visible by all meanings of the word. They were a part of her now like a tattoo she couldn't remove.

And yet?

They had faded. They had healed, faded and recovered.

She stood there, the afternoon light shining through the window.

"Estás bien, cariño?" Elizabeth asked.

Catra nodded and shut her hands. "It's just…weird. I never thought I'd come this far, be alive, even after everything that happened," she said. She looked at Elizabeth and smiled.

Something fluttered in her chest.

Love.

That's what it was.

Love.

"I'm here. I'm loved. I'm alive. Isn't that such a beautiful thing?" she asked.

Elizabeth looked at her, "Where's this coming from?"

She shrugged, "I'm thankful for once. I feel…okay." She sat on the dining room chair and looked out the window. "I think…I want to join the Rebellion," she said.

“Oh, yes?” Elizabeth asked. She stood up from her seat and walked over to her.

“Yeah. I think I’m ready,” Catra said. She shut her eyes, sighed, and gave Elizabeth a smile she never thought she’d smile.

Elizabeth smiled back and held open her arms.

Catra easily leaned into the hug.

“I’m always here for you, cariño. I’m always here if you ever need a home to go to in the Crimson Waste,” she said. She kissed the side of her head so tenderly.

Catra cried.

She hugged her tight and she didn’t let go.

She didn’t let go.

And she wouldn’t for quite some time before she’d leave the room to pack her things for the journey ahead.

Chapter End Notes

> So! Catra finally decided to go to Bright Moon and join the Rebellion. How is she going to get there when the last time she tried to live in the Crimson Waste, she almost died of poisoning? We'll find out in the next and last chapter of Altitude, eh? I'm planning on posting it the day after tomorrow my time. I hope you all enjoyed reading this chapter. I had a lot of fun writing it and it was a real blast writing the last chapter of Altitude, too.
> Also! We finally get to see Adora in the last chapter! However, since this was a purely Catra-centered fanfiction, I feel bad for not having much Catradora in it. Regardless, this was a fun chapter to write and I did a lot of editing of it. My next fic might be a more Catradora-like fic though. Maybe. We'll see. Anyway, have a good day or night! See you overmorrow!

New-Washed Hand

Chapter Summary

> Finally on her way to Bright Moon, Catra begins her journey. Due to circumstances, however, she finds herself in an eerily familiar situation she was in when she was first dropped off here in the Crimson Waste many months ago.

Chapter Notes

> So here we are, the last chapter of Altitude. I really hope you all enjoyed this one. I really want to write more of a post-canon Altitude kind of situation. So! That's what I will do. However, this will be the final chapter of this actual fanfic. Read on, go forth, enjoy the journey for it is finally over.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Traveling, it turned out, was a long stretch and took quite a long time.

She packed up what little she had.

Her clothes, her weapons, her toothbrush and toothpaste, items, items, items.

Elizabeth had gotten her new things to use in the Crimson Waste.

Catra packed her things all in one suitcase. It fit well, luckily. She didn’t know how some other people might not be able to do that.

Regardless.

With a simple zip of the suitcase, a sigh, and a lowering of her shoulders, she was ready.

She sat back on her heels, “Elizabeth!”

“Yes?”

“I’m ready!” She picked up the suitcase and made her way to the door.

Elizabeth leaned against the front doorway. She looked over as Catra walked in with her bag. “Ready to steal a skiff?”

“Oh, fuck yeah I am,” Catra said. She smiled and set her bag down by the door.

Elizabeth laughed at this and at the rolling desert before them. “So, you ready? Really?” she asked.

Catra sighed and smiled, “Yeah. I am.”

—

Surprisingly, it wasn’t that hard to steal the skiff and extra cans of gas along with it.

She and Elizabeth snuck along the wall. Catra knew this place, or at least the Horde’s patterns, well enough.

She’d ruled it for over 3 years by now.

She had made the squadrons’ formations, their strategies.

This one was specifically Hordak’s work now based on how shoddy it was.

She gestured for Elizabeth to follow her as she snuck through the shadows into the loading bay.

Go.

Elizabeth easily snuck by and, with a jerk of her wrist and a puff of air, easily tranquilized the guards next to the skiffs.

Catra didn’t really want to tranquilize them but she knew she’d need to because they were people, too.

Elizabeth loaded her dart gun as Catra tranquilized the others. She gestured for Elizabeth to follow her again as they went through the loud area.

She started dragging them around to a corner and, after a quick loading up, checking of the gas tank, she started up the skiff.

They escaped from the place with Horde soldiers scrambling around them and cursing as they drove past them.

"They're probably not going to follow us. They have enough," Catra said as she drove the skiff out of the Valley and into the desert. She and Elizabeth got to the house in such little time that she was almost amazed at the progress.

This would be beautiful.

She stopped the skiff by the house and turned it off. She jumped off and went to help Elizabeth down too. Elizabeth simply laughed and easily jumped down too.

"I'm not that old, mija. Thank you," she said.

After they loaded her things into the skiff, she paused.

"So…this is goodbye, isn't it?" Catra said softly.

"Remember," Elizabeth held her by the shoulders gently and smiled, "you'll always have a home here in the Crimson Waste. I'll be here as long as I'm alive."

Catra smiled and pulled her into a tight hug. "I love you."

Elizabeth's body shook and she hugged her back, "I love you, too. Be good out there."

Catra chuckled, "I always am."

Elizabeth kissed her temple and nuzzled her face against her cheek.

Catra started to purr and teared up. She nuzzled her back and rocked slowly. “Take care of yourself, Mom,” she said.

“You know I will,” Elizabeth said with a smile Catra could feel. “This is the first time I’ve heard you purr.”

“I didn’t know I still could,” Catra said. She was still purring. She broke off the hug and looked into her eyes. “Thank you. For helping me,” she said.

Elizabeth smiled and cupped her cheek, “Of course. I love you. Be good.”

Catra sniffled and nodded with shut eyes. She bumped her head against Elizabeth’s neck and finally stepped back.

In silence, she climbed onto the skiff and started it up. They parted ways.

Catra’s cheeks were wet with tears as she drove off to the desert.

The desert rolled in a blur under the skiff. It waved and she relied on her sense of direction and the moons to guide her. She glanced up at the sky snd gauged her location again. It guided her through the afternoon when she finally stopped to take a break and fill up the tank.

It really burned through gas fast despite her upgrades to the machinery she’d instructed them to make.

She lay on the desert sands and watched the moons set. She climbed onto the skiff again, set up the tent in the skiff, wrapped herself in the sleeping bag, and zipped herself up.

She hoped that nothing would do anything while she slept.

But she slept anyway.

—

The fields unrolled before her very eyes. Flowers bloomed and grew through the grass with confident faces that rose high above the tall blades. They shivered in cold winds and Catra shut her eyes. She took a breath in and let it out despite not needing it. She knew this was a dream, she knew it by now but didn't care, didn't do anything.

There, again.

Adora.

She stood in place this time. She waited and waited, trying not to follow.

She had accepted it, she guessed at this point.

Adora looked at her, finally catching sight of her. She smiled so big, so dopey.

Lovingly.

That's what that expression was.

Love.

Catra finally ran towards her.

Even if it turned into a nightmare, even if something went wrong.

She was used to it by now.

She didn't even care.

But Adora didn't go away. Adora didn't leave this time.

So neither did she.

She jumped forward and, with a crash.

—

Woke up to the sound of an animal tearing apart the skiff.

"Oye!" she shouted. She scrambled out of the tent and took her whip out. She swung it through the air and lashed the giant lizard's hide with the heavy whip.

It sent a spray of blood through the air and the lizard screeched and fled with a hiss.

Catra looked up at the sky.

Barely moonrise.

That works.

She started up the skiff after making sure it wasn't too damaged and started the journey onwards.

—

So on she went.

She looked down at the map, glancing at it while she drove the skiff.

On the right track, seemed like.

She looked up at the sky, at the moons above her, for a second, to make sure she wasn't straying yet.

When she looked back down, the desert spire was starting to show up.

First checkpoint.

She stopped by the spire and sat cross-legged on the skiff. She grabbed her suitcase full of supplies and took out a bag of jerky in it. She started to eat it slowly now. The moons, still high, but not the ones that gave the most heat, looked beautiful right now.

While she sat there, she thought. She didn't have much else to do other than just sit here and think, really.

So she did.

Strange.

She looked at the spire she remembered seeing on her journey through the Waste.

Its shape was twisted, lumpy, a natural rock formation that was worn down over so many years. So, so many.

She looked inside herself then.

She took a breath.

And let herself think.

"Am I really ready to go back?" she asked herself aloud. She lay back and held her jerky in one hand and continued to eat it while her other hand lay spread out at her side, palm open and brand visible.

She didn't want to wear her gloves right now.

She shut her eyes and let the answer come to her naturally.

Yes. I am.

It doesn't seem like it yet.

I am, though. I am ready to go join the Rebellion.

Am I convincing myself that or am I really ready?

I'm being honest. I'm ready.

She sighed and shut her eyes, waiting as the heat from the moon started to very slowly creep up the horizon. It eyed her with its colorful surface and whispered a good morning to her.

She watched it rise for a bit, letting herself enjoy it before she thought more again.

She thought of what would happen if she'd just given up, if she'd stayed in the Crimson Waste.

Who would she become?

She felt her ears, one torn from walking through a particularly rough patch of brambles.

Maybe she would've gotten piercings, done some unhealthy things.

Maybe she would've got into fights, got into some scuffles.

Maybe.

But who was she now, instead? She'd only been in the Crimson Waste with Elizabeth for a month. What makes her think she's already ready to go to the Rebellion? What makes her think that she's good enough now to go and see Adora again?

Her breaths were coming out sharper and faster.

She stopped.

"Stop," she said aloud.

She took a deep breath in and imagined her thoughts like leaves going down a river. They all went down fast, a flurry of them one after the other.

She let it out.

The leaves moved fast, they kept going.

She was a failure.

She was a horrible person.

She wasn’t enough.

Terrible, horrible.

She watched the leaves go down the river.

Her thoughts started again and she cautiously watched them go.

She’d done so many terrible things to others. Why?

Why?

She didn’t know.

No. She did.

Why?

She took a breath again, really thought of the answer.

“I was…angry. I was hurt, I wanted to hurt everyone so they would know what I was feeling. I wanted to hurt Adora because I thought she was evil, I hated her. I wanted to do better than her to prove that I was worth something, too. I wanted to make Glimmer and Bow hurt because I thought they’d taken her away from me,” she took another breath and let it out slowly, “I loved her and thought that she’d abandoned me because I wasn’t enough for her, that I was too much and not enough. I was too much to handle.”

She waited for a bit. She let herself listen to the animals around her.

“But I’m not. I’m not too much. I am enough, I am loved by her. She doesn’t hate me. I was hurting myself in the process of trying to make her hurt too.”

She looked up at the sky and took another bite of her jerky. She chewed it in silence and let herself enjoy the warmth of the moonlight.

This was okay. This was alright.

She deserved to be happy, too.

Ever since talking to Elizabeth she realized something.

Vulnerability was not weakness.

And weakness was safe sometimes.

It was okay.

She'd be okay.

Emotions were not weakness, no matter how much they hurt.

Emotions were a part of life, necessary, okay, healthy.

She finished her jerky and decided it was time to go now.

So she stood up, checked her supplies, which were now low.

Mostly on purpose.

And finally started up the skiff and continued her path going to Bright Moon once more.

She spent another couple of hours adjusting her path of travel and going for the edge of the desert, which would still take quite some time even at this fast pace. Plus—

The skiff lurched.

She let out a yelp and held on, the skiff shifting around and lurching forward as she stumbled with it. There was a boom and the smell of smoke.

Smoke.

She immediately lept off of the skiff and rolled onto the sand.

The skiff drove another couple of yards before it finally exploded in flames.

"No!" she cried.

She ran to it and hoisted what she could from the flames and smoke before fleeing again.

Shards of metal.

She raised an arm to shield her face as shards of metal and machinery flew through the air and started to rain down on her. Everything burned around and cut through her skin like butter.

She whined and ignored it mostly as she waited for the skiff to finally die away.

She sat down next to her supplies and checked herself over.

Gashes on her arms and legs, one on her cheek, luckily missing her eye. More had hit her arms and shredded through them too.

Damaged, hurt, wounded.

She opened up the bag with shaking hands and took out the first aid kit she and Elizabeth had made. She wiped off the blood and groaned in pain. Blood ran down her arms and dripped onto the sand.

She cursed and pressed the wipe on the biggest one, holding it until it stopped bleeding as heavily. She grabbed the gauze from the kit and wrapped it over the wounds with another whimper of pain.

She could deal with them all. It wasn't as much as she'd thought.

She checked over herself after wrapping the bigger ones.

Nothing else.

She checked again and found a scratch on her finger and put a small bandage over it after washing it off with a wipe and putting jelly on it.

Her vision was starting to clear up now. The world caved in, crashed.

She collapsed in a heap and groaned in pain. Her body shook, she felt a wave of nausea, and started to breathe as slowly as she could to calm her heart down.

This was fine. She was fine. She had helped herself. Move on.

So she looked at her supplies.

She knew now.

She knew how to survive out here now.

She got up on shaky legs, making her way to the suitcase and anything that could be scavenged from it.

Probably the most she could get was the toothbrush and toothpaste, first aid kit, compass, water bottle, firestarter, and some of her papers and drawing supplies.

She still had her whip and dagger on her person along with her gloves. That was better.

The tent, however, was unsalvagable.

Oh, so just like when she first came here but slightly better. Or worse? A mixture of the two.

Great.

She stood up and shot an azimuth real quick, kept it around the rock, and started her trek on shaky feet. She walked at a fast but sustainable pace towards the edge of the Crimson Waste.

Luckily, it’d be about a 20-mile walk from here.

Definitely not that bad.

So she walked and walked and walked.

Soon, she'd be thirsty.

Boil, mash, and strain the Lengua Del Diablo to get drinkable water. The pulp was the poisonous part.

She grabbed her gloves and put them on, enjoying their weight and strength. She clawed one up nearby, using her dagger to help. She started to take it apart. The scent was bitter and almost acidic. It smelled of anger and pain and rage.

She started up a fire and took out a chunk of the skiff she'd taken as a makeshift bowl for now. She heated it up and boiled the inside in the water.

While she waited, she looked around to look for tubers to eat too.

There.

She avoided the brambles that's turn you to stone for a moment and dug into the ground for tubers. She gathered them up and walked back to where the water was, a bit from her bottle.

She took out the puffed-up inside and mashed it up in the bowl. After looking through it, she filtered as much as she could through one of her burnt shirts and drank the water.

After getting her drink, she filtered the rest into her bottle. The tubers could only be eaten only after being roasted for a bit. So she grabbed a branch, took off the thorns, and cooked the tubers over the flames.

This would have to do for now.

So she cooked some more and hunted some lizards. She would cook them, too.

Just to get something to eat for later.

She kicked out the fire and pressed on with her partially damaged body, her items, and her food and water.

She eyed her compass as she walked down the desert sands. Each step was gradually starting to be more painful as the moons got higher and the sand got hotter.

So she walked, and walked, and walked anyway.

Luckily, she'd been closer to the edge of the Crimson Waste than she'd thought.

But she still could only travel during dawn and dusk. The afternoon was far too hot and night was far too cold to function easily.

Her arms and legs were still hurting from where she'd gotten hurt by the skiff exploding. She'd need actual medical attention for those.

For now, she kept walking.

The moon was starting to come up and it was starting to get hotter.

She retreated under an overhang and sat in the shade. She took her roasted lizards and her tubers out and started to have a meal.

She took out her paper. The quality was relatively good. It wasn't nearly as good as the paper she had at Elizabeth's house, untouched and unburnt. It was scratchy and crisped at the edges where the fire had burnt some of it. Luckily, most of it remained in one usable piece.

She took out her drawing charcoal and drew in the afternoon light. Not having much else to do here, boredom could be a real bitch.

She remembered her time with Elizabeth. She remembered making coffee out of the Lengua Del Diablo, making chocolate syrup out of it. It tasted so bitter and nutty and the coffee had been a chocolatey, nutty liquid. Not nearly as caffeinated as what she'd had scavenged back in the Horde though.

So she tapped her charcoal against her chin and rolled it in her hands between her fingers. The temptation to chew on it was so strong but, unlike pencils, she couldn't exactly chew on the charcoal without almost dying.

Again.

She shivered at the memory of when she'd been slowly poisoning herself over the course of a month. She'd almost died. She was so scared and wondered if she'd ever make it out of the Waste alive.

It hadn't been fun, to say the least, and was deadly at the most.

She eyed the Lengua Del Diablo nearby and hummed.

She knew the kind of effect chewing on the roots had, plus it was a nice gum to work her jaws with.

She decided against it and continued to think of what to draw.

Her muse came in the form of a small lizard walking by. She bent down and immediately started to get a basic outline of it. Her eyes barely strayed from the small animal. She finished drawing it just before it moved away. She started to sketch it again, focusing on the fluidity of the pose and the natural quality of the lizard.

She drew it looking at her, focusing on its eyes.

It displayed a frill and she decided to sketch that out before staring up to hiss at it. It hissed back and she lunged toward it.

The lizard reared on two legs but alas.

She pounced on it and broke its spine with her weight.

“You were a worthy opponent,” she said.

She didn’t know what to do with it. It was one of the inedible ones that were too bony to really be worth the effort.

Why did she even kill it?

Probably because it was going to attack her and was the size of a small cat.

She heard the familiar sounds of the dragons that circle the air above a kill and looked up.

Two were circling nearby.

Something big had died.

She gathered her things and made her way, following the dragons to the source.

A large, dead something was lying half-eaten on the sand.

She crouched down, took out her drawing supplies, and drew the dragons with their feathered wings and vulture-like body structure.

She sketched them much like she had the lizard.

They eyed her warily and kept eating. They fought amongst one another, which she tried to sketch out too.

Overall, a fun exercise.

She was sweating now though. It was way too hot.

She eyed the moon.

A little past noon by now.

That was fast. Huh…

She packed her things again and stood up with a sigh. With careful movements, she backed away from the dragons. They continued their feast.

What were the scavengers of the Crimson Waste doing with the skiff's machinery? They could always find something useful out of it.

Especially considering how sturdy the material was, it would be a horrible idea to pass up that opportunity.

She lay under a different overhang and watched animals skitter around her. She twirled her dagger in one hand and whistled softly. It echoed around the rock walls and the empty canyon. It made it sound nearly ethereal.

So she shut her eyes and kept whistling to herself, something she'd heard the Rebellion sing when they were in battle.

The air was far too dry for her liking but whatever, she'd learned to deal with it by now.

She chuckled to herself as she finished whistling the song. "I can't believe I'm joining the Rebellion," she said. She shook her head and stared at the sky. "Am I really ready?" she asked herself again.

Yes. Yes, I am.

She nodded and lay back on the cool rock. She shut her eyes and sighed. Sleepiness washed over her as she lay there and the moon started to dip and lower in the sky.

She wished she'd brought a hat or something to cover her face as the heat started to wash over her. The moons' light was shining relatively hard on her now.

That light was bright, turning the backs of her eyelids red as she lay there.

It was tiring.

So she moved a bit to the side and out of the light. She sighed again and waited for the heat to pass by her. She opened and closed the compass, she made sure her wounds weren't infected.

She waited.

Finally, it was starting to cool down a bit.

She ate another meal, got up, and started her journey once more.

—

It only took until night had fallen to leave the Crimson Waste at last. It hadn't taken too long and there were still some signs of light before nighttime finally would fall.

She stumbled through the plains and looked up.

The Whispering Woods.

Here we go.

She pushed into the Whispering Woods and hoped that maybe she wouldn't get lost here.

She didn't know these woods too well, but at least had come on enough raids on them to at least have an idea.

The trees seemed to eye her, towering over her as she walked on.

Bright Moon, here I come.

The woods were not an unfriendly place. She'd found that out after a raid had spotted a particularly beautiful inhabitant of it. The deer animal had eyed her in the face before she'd run it over.

She tried to push that thought away as she continued to walk.

She wasn’t quite sure how long the Whispering Woods was, but they’d seemed to be fairly large before she’d get to Bright Moon at least.

The path ahead was a long one, but one she was sure she’d get to eventually.

It was going to be long, hard, potentially treacherous, but she’d make it.

She’d make it.

So she walked over breaking sticks and dead leaves that crunched underfoot.

She walked on.

She kept walking on.

The only way here now was forward.

She looked up.

Voices.

She recognized them.

Her heart and body worked on impulse and she climbed up a tree.

She perched there and watched the forest floor. Her tail swung languidly through the air.

Her ear flicked and she thought.

Who was she now? After these three? four? Months? She was somehow still the same but such a different person. She felt like someone had taken her apart and made her really look at herself. She felt like.

Someone had taken her and stood her in front of a mirror. She’d seen her reflection last in Elizabeth’s house.

Her skin was tanned, her face harder, eyes empty and yet awake and focused, her body muscular and her stature taller in a sense.

Different.

She thought back to what had happened.

Just three months ago she'd been in the Horde convinced that happiness only came in the form of how many people she hurt or slept with.

Now?

As she looked at the two, Glimmer and Bow, walking through the woods.

She decided.

That wasn't what happiness was. That she'd known someone that actually loved her in such a way that she'd never known. A parent's love. She'd known now that Adora loved her.

But.

Parental love was something she'd never experienced until just a month or two ago.

She had lost track of time.

She jumped from the tree and followed the two with light steps and followed them from a distance.

She'd do something different.

She'd be someone different.

—

They kept walking and stopping, occasionally saying something about a weapon. They also talked about how upset Adora seemed to be.

Ever since she was gone, missing, not seen for three or four months.

Catra watched as the woods opened up, as the two walked off.

As Bright Moon showed itself to her.

She knew they wouldn't greet her with open arms. They would be livid, they would be furious.

They had every reason to be.

But she wanted to join them.

And maybe.

Just maybe.

That'd be good enough of a start.

When she reached the gates of the castle, she immediately cleared her throat.

The guards snapped at attention and brandished their weapons.

Catra raised her hands in surrender. "I'm here to join the Rebellion. I have information on the Horde," she said.

They looked at her quizzically and grabbed her by the wrists. They tied up her hands and walked towards the castle doors.

Catra was in awe, absolutely shocked, at just how massive and grand the castle was.

She was led through the doors.

Here goes nothing.

"Tell the Queen that there is someone here. She says she wants to join the Rebellion," the guard said.

The other guard nodded and briskly walked off.

Catra passed by tapestries and looked over the ones hanging on the walls.

She spotted it.

Her heart dropped and she averted her eyes as Queen Angella's statue passed by them.

That was her fault.

The doors opened with a creak and there.

There she was.

Adora.

Off to the side, Adora stood there and she didn't look at her quite yet. She had her turned in her direction but didn't seem to see her yet.

Until she got closer.

Catra watched as Glimmer sat on the throne with a straight body, looking regal and mighty somehow.

"Is that…" Adora whispered nearby.

"I think," Bow said.

Catra paid her no mind or at least tried not to. She was stopped and easily dropped to her knees and bowed to Glimmer.

There was a whirring of magic and a color washed over her.

"That's a truth spell. You won't be able to lie under it," Glimmer said. She sounded like she was trying to sound regal.

"You won't need it," Catra said. She straightened her back and smiled. "I'm here to join the Rebellion, Queen Glimmer. I'll tell you

all that you want to know about the Horde," she said.

Glimmer looked at her with suspicion and looked over at Adora.

Catra followed her gaze.

Adora was staring at her with something that looked either like shock or confusion or joy or something between all three.

She smiled in a toothy and not unfriendly way and winked at her before turning back to Glimmer again.

"Tell me, Horde Scum," Glimmer looked down her nose, "why are you really here?"

Catra hummed, "I went through what you could call a life journey, near-death experience, and decided I'd join you guys. That's it."

Glimmer looked at her. She stayed there for a long time, looked at the guards, and nodded, "Take her to the cell. The spare room," she said.

The guards nodded and helped her up. Catra felt the magic wear off and followed them out the door.

Adora was definitely on the verge of tears by now based on her shining eyes and covered mouth.

She smiled and looked away again.

What an idiot.

—

When she got into the room, Glimmer could be heard whispering outside of the door.

"I know the spell worked but do you really think that she wants to join us? I mean— she hasn't exactly been the most friendly to us lately," Glimmer said.

“Glimmer. She’s been missing for three, almost four months now. I don’t know what happened to her but she was definitely telling the truth. Did you see how she looked?” Adora said.

“I know but—“

“Give her a chance, okay?”

“Okay.”

The doors opened and Catra simply flicked an ear.

Adora and Glimmer walked in and Catra zeroed in on Adora’s expression.

She looked so happy, but conflicted, mostly like she wanted to believe her. She was watching her and looking her over.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra smiled again and tried to suppress her urge to purr, “it’s nice to see you again."

Chapter End Notes

> So we got an obligatory "Hey, Adora" ending which is hot I guess. Catra is basically a new person now at this point let's be real and honest here. Also! Congrats! It is the end of Altitude! I hope you all enjoyed it because it was a blast and a half to write! This made me really want to write more multi-chapter works if I'm being honest. These are fun to do. Regardless, I am here, I am queer and ready to tell you all a story about the post-Horde Prime Altitude canon. I actually figured out how it'd all work and all which took just about all of my one(1) brain cells to do. It was fun, though. Anyway! I will be here, but this marks the end of Altitude as the main story. Thank you, all of you, I really hope you enjoyed this. I know I had a lot of fun writing it and it was great to hear from all of you too.

End Notes

Thank you for reading this! I really hope you enjoyed it. It was based off of/named after the poem Altitude by Lola Ridge. I thought it fit the theme of the fic well enough. Thank you!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!